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**Research on Public Opinion of Administrative Records:
Cognitive Testing Report**

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Abstract

RTI International staff conducted cognitive testing with 40 participants to further assess a draft survey instrument intended to measure public opinion about the use of administrative records by the Census Bureau and about the creation of a demographic frame. Census Bureau staff provided the instrument for testing. The cognitive testing evaluated the survey questions for possible issues that may hinder a respondent's answering process. Findings from the research resulted in revisions to the question prior to fielding the web survey.

This report explains the cognitive testing methods, including the description of the target population and participant eligibility criteria, the strategies of participant recruitment and screening, and the survey questions tested during cognitive interviewing. Additionally, this report includes the qualitative analysis of the cognitive interviews, the recommendations for question revisions and the feedback and the revision decisions for the final questionnaire provided by the Census Bureau.

Keywords: public opinion, administrative records

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Research on Public Opinion of Administrative Records: Cognitive Testing Report

Final Report

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Contents

Section	Page
1. Overview	1-1
2. Research Methods	2-1
2.1 Cognitive Testing Overview	2-1
2.2 Target Population and Participation Eligibility Criteria	2-1
2.3 Methods of Participant Recruitment and Screening	2-2
2.3.1 Web Screening.....	2-2
2.3.2 Phone Screening and In-Person Screening	2-3
2.4 Instrumentation and Data Collection	2-3
2.5 Qualitative Data Analysis Strategy.....	2-4
3. Overall Themes	3-1
3.1 Different Reactions to Community and Individual Benefits of Government Data Collection	3-1
3.2 Varying Perception of Risks and Benefits	3-2
3.3 Different Opinions about Data Sharing	3-4
3.4 Unfamiliarity Regarding the Census Bureau's Function.....	3-5
3.5 Desire for Additional Contextual Information about Survey.....	3-6
4. Question by Question Findings	4-1
References	R-1
Appendix	
Appendix A. Original Survey Questions	A-1

Tables

Number		Page
Table 2-1.	Desired Participant Characteristics	2-1
Table 4-1.	Responses to Q01	4-1
Table 4-2.	Responses to Q02	4-3
Table 4-3.	Responses to Q03	4-6
Table 4-4.	Responses to Q04	4-8
Table 4-5.	Responses to Q05	4-11
Table 4-6.	Responses to Q06	4-14
Table 4-7.	Responses to Q07	4-17
Table 4-8.	Responses to Q08	4-19
Table 4-9.	Responses to Q09	4-22
Table 4-10.	Responses to Q10	4-24
Table 4-11.	Responses to Q11	4-26
Table 4-12.	Responses to Q12	4-29
Table 4-13.	Responses to Q13	4-30
Table 4-14.	Responses to Q14	4-30
Table 4-15.	Responses to Q15	4-34
Table 4-16.	Responses to Q16	4-34
Table 4-17.	Responses to Q17	4-37
Table 4-18.	Responses to Q18	4-40
Table 4-19.	Responses to Q19	4-43
Table 4-20.	Responses to Q20	4-46
Table 4-21.	Comprehension of the Frames by Language	4-47
Table 4-22.	Responses to Q20 by Exposure Sequence	4-47
Table 4-23.	Responses to Q20 by Frames	4-48
Table 4-24.	Participants Who Changed Responses to Q20 between Frames.....	4-50
Table 4-25.	Responses to Q21	4-53
Table 4-26.	Responses to Q23	4-58
Table 4-27.	Responses to Q24	4-59
Table 4-28.	Responses to Q25	4-59
Table 4-29.	Responses to Q26	4-61
Table 4-30.	Responses to Q27	4-62
Table 4-31.	Responses to Q28	4-62
Table 4-32.	Responses to Q29	4-64
Table 4-33.	Responses to Q30	4-65
Table 4-34.	Responses to Q31	4-65

Table 4-35.	Responses to Q32	4-66
Table 4-36.	Responses to Q33	4-68
Table 4-37.	Responses to Q34	4-69
Table 4-38.	Responses to Q35	4-69
Table 4-39.	Responses to Q36	4-71
Table 4-40.	Responses to Q37	4-72
Table 4-41.	Responses to Q38	4-73
Table 4-42.	Responses to Q39	4-75
Table 4-43.	Responses to Q40	4-76
Table 4-44.	Responses to Q41	4-77
Table 4-45.	Responses to Q42	4-77
Table 4-46.	Responses to Q43	4-79
Table 4-47.	Responses to Q44	4-81

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1. Overview

RTI International staff conducted cognitive testing with 40 participants to further assess a draft survey instrument intended to measure public opinion about the use of administrative records by the Census Bureau and about the creation of a demographic frame. Census Bureau staff provided the instrument for testing. The cognitive testing evaluated the survey questions for possible issues that may hinder a respondent's answering process. Findings from the research resulted in revisions to the question prior to fielding the web survey.

This report explains the cognitive testing methods, including the description of the target population and participant eligibility criteria, the strategies of participant recruitment and screening, and the survey questions tested during cognitive interviewing. Additionally, this report includes the qualitative analysis of the cognitive interviews, the recommendations for question revisions and the feedback and the revision decisions for the final questionnaire provided by the Census Bureau.

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2. Research Methods

2.1 Cognitive Testing Overview

Cognitive testing consists of one-on-one in-person interviews (via either face-to-face or virtual communication mode) to assess a questionnaire in terms of general comprehension, clarity of question and response wording, effectiveness of skip logic, and visual aids. The goal is to gain an understanding of how well the questions work when administered to a sample of the survey's target population. The interviews follow a protocol with pre-scripted probes. Cognitive interviewers also use spontaneous probes to gain a better understanding of questions. Cognitive interviewing works best for the following:

- Learning about the respondents' thought processes while answering the questions;
- Measuring the response process, including comprehension, retrieval, judgement, and response;
- Observing non-verbal, human reactions;
- Testing navigation in self-administered modes, particularly mail surveys;
- Assessing the potential for measurement error in survey items;
- Examining potentially big or complex issues; and
- Gauging opinions on the survey as a whole.

The cognitive interviews for the Research on Public Opinion on Administrative Records (RoPOAR) were conducted virtually using Microsoft Teams, providing the flexibility to achieve geographic diversity with the participant recruitment.

2.2 Target Population and Participation Eligibility Criteria

The cognitive testing target population for the Research on Public Opinion on Administrative Records project was non-institutionalized English-speaking adults and monolingual Spanish-speaking adults (18+) who live in the United States. RTI assessed prospective recruits' characteristics through a project screener and invited those with desired traits to participate in cognitive interviews. RTI worked with the Census Bureau to operationalize these desired traits and set quotas or minimums for recruitment. Table 2.1 lists the characteristics used to recruit participants for the cognitive interviews.

Table 2-1. Desired Participant Characteristics

Age	Gender	Number of children in a household
Race	Urban/rural living	Education attainment
Language spoken at home		

2.3 Methods of Participant Recruitment and Screening

To ensure efficient and successful recruitment of the target populations, the RTI team used a combination of online recruitment strategies and community-based methods. Specifically, we used online advertising and targeted community-based advertising to solicit participation based on the desired participant characteristics.

Online Advertisements. RTI placed advertisements on Craigslist in a variety of markets. The advertisements described the research and included a link to the web-based screener. Potential participants navigated to the online screener and answered questions to determine eligibility for the study. We conducted interviews remotely, through Microsoft Teams, and were thus able to recruit nationally. Online advertising was primarily used for recruiting English-speaking interview participants.

Community-Based Strategies. Recruitment also took place using community-based strategies. RTI's partner, Research Support Services, reached out to community-based organizations that work with monolingual Spanish speakers for assistance getting the word out about the study to their clients to recruit Spanish speakers. Screening for these individuals often took place in person or over the phone.

2.3.1 Web Screening

RTI and the Census Bureau collaborated to develop the eligibility screener. The screener included questions to ascertain eligibility and to measure variables of interest that allow us to recruit a diverse sample of cognitive interview participants.

The screener was hosted on Qualtrics, a survey data collection platform hosted within Census Bureau's virtual desktop interface (VDI) under the Census Bureau's institutional license. The web link of the screening instrument was included in online advertisements and physical flyers for recruitment.

Participants clicked on the link in the advertisements and answered the questions in the screening survey. The data from the web screener was downloaded to a recruitment tracking sheet (also located within the Census Bureau's VDI) to aid in scheduling and interviewing. For the recruitment of English participants, 140 individuals were screened via the web screener, and 42 were recruited for interviews. We completed 25 interviews from these recruits. At the same time, 10 of the recruits did not respond to our outreach effort (i.e., two email attempts). Three did not attend their scheduled interview, two withdrew their participation during the interview, and two participants were excluded from the study because of technological challengers or language barriers that resulted in termination of the interview. For the recruitment of Spanish participants, 22 individuals were screened and recruited to participate in the interviews. We completed 15 interviews with these recruits. Similarly, four recruits were considered ineligible for participation, one recruit declined to be screened further, and two did not attend their scheduled interviews.

2.3.2 Phone Screening and In-Person Screening

For certain characteristics where eligible individuals are less likely to complete an online screener (e.g., monolingual Spanish speakers), advertisements included a phone number instead of a web link. Calls were received by Spanish-speaking recruiters who administered the screener over the phone and entered respondents' answers into the web screener. Recruiters were able to determine eligibility based on responses and assigned cases to interviewers. English advertisements did not include a phone number, and interested parties were routed to the online screener.

2.4 Instrumentation and Data Collection

The cognitive interviews were conducted via Microsoft Teams using section-by-section probing; the protocol featured concurrent probes administered throughout the interview.

Audio and Video Recording. Cognitive interviewers audio recorded all interviews where participants consented to such recording. If the participant did not agree, the interviewer took detailed notes during the cognitive interview. All participants consented to either audio or video recording for their interviews. Interview recordings were delivered to the Census Bureau after each round of interviews.

Informed Consent. Cognitive interviewers obtained informed consent from English participants using the electronic consent forms provided by the Census Bureau and programmed in Qualtrics. Participants' data from the consent form were submitted to the Census Bureau at the end of data collection. For Spanish participants, cognitive interviewers obtained verbal consent before proceeding with the interview.

Payment. Participants received a \$40 incentive for the virtual interviews. The incentives were furnished via Amazon gift card. The project team obtained a payment voucher or payment record at the time of payment to participants. All incentive vouchers were submitted to the Census Bureau.

Case Summaries. RTI prepared case summaries for each completed interview. The summaries captured the interview narrative, including highlights of reactions to the probes and notable observations from interviewers. For Spanish interviews, summaries were written in English, but key concepts or thoughts were provided in Spanish with back-translations in English to aid understanding and maintain context.

Interviewer Training. A project-specific training prepared interviewers to conduct interviews. All cognitive interviewers attended a 4-hour virtual training that (1) discussed study background and research objectives; (2) reviewed the testing questions and what they are intended to measure; (3) reviewed the scripted probes and research questions they are intended to address; (4) discussed informed consent, confidentiality, and Title 13 requirements; (5) discussed logistics; and (6) reviewed writing effective case summaries.

Project staff provided copies of interviewer training materials to the Census Bureau. Bilingual interviewers received an additional training that focused on unique issues related to conducting interviews in Spanish.

Development of Interview Protocols. The Census Bureau and RTI reviewed and discussed the testing goals as part of project start-up activities. These discussions established the necessary context to develop the interview protocols and item-level probes.

RTI developed the interview protocol with the Census Bureau's input and review.

The interview protocols were developed in English and then translated into Spanish. The protocols documented the administration details, consent forms, and materials required for cognitive interviewing, including a list of scripted cognitive interview probes to focus on how respondents settled on a response and on their understanding of specific terms and phrases.

The first protocols developed included 45 questions, with probes on nearly all questions. However, it was clear once interviewing began that all 45 questions could not be reviewed with respondents without increasing the length of the interviews. To keep the estimated burden at 1 hour, 14 questions were removed. The decision to remove these questions was based on successful implementation on previous Census Bureau surveys and little feedback from the interviews conducted so far. This decision also allowed for more in-depth questioning about the remaining 31 questions. Ten interviews were completed with the original 45-question protocol.

Based on the feedback from the first 18 interviews (10 with the original protocol and 8 with the reduced protocol), several adjustments were made to the questions to test proposed revisions. Three questions (Q4, Q8, and Q11) were moved to directly after Q22 to attempt to provide participants with further context. We hypothesized that this move may give participants additional context by answering Q17–Q22 first, before answering more general questions. We believed this could help increase confidence in participants' responses. We also made several adjustments to the wording of items in Q44 to improve clarity. Because a second round of interviewing was not feasible, implementing these changes during data collection allowed us to gather some limited feedback to inform final question wording and order. Seven participants completed this final version of the protocol.

2.5 Qualitative Data Analysis Strategy

The RTI and RSS team used a systematic process to analyze the cognitive interview data and address the research questions. The process began with the analysts reading all case summaries to familiarize themselves with the data. The case summaries were imported into a Microsoft Excel spreadsheet allowing the analysts to easily sort and filter the data to compare responses with questions and probes across all participants. Next, analysts

synthesized and reduced the data to meaningful categories and themes (e.g., misinterpreted term X or concept Y was not understood consistently). Some of these themes were identified in advance based on the testing goals. Other themes emerged during analysis. Overall conclusions were drawn based on individual findings. For questions that performed poorly, analysts provided recommendations for improving the questions. Those revised questions were adapted for use in the Ipsos panel survey.

In Chapter 3, we present the overarching and common themes observed from the cognitive interview findings. Chapter 4 describes detailed findings, revision recommendations and feedback from the Census Bureau (if applicable) for each cognitive testing instrument question.

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3. Overall Themes

This chapter explores common question issues in further detail. Most of the cognitive testing findings focused on the issues identified in the common themes discussed below—especially how respondents understand the question and specific terms in the question. A complete write-up of the recommendations is included in Chapter 4, which discusses proposed updates for each question.

3.1 Different Reactions to Community and Individual Benefits of Government Data Collection

In the instrument, there are several questions that asked respondents about their opinions of the risk and benefits of government data collection. A common issue identified during the cognitive interview was that participants found community benefits to be more concrete than individual benefits when considering their answers to these questions. While probing for examples of community risks and benefits, the most commonly mentioned benefit was the allocation of funding or resources for social services and improvements to the community such as funding for building or fixing sidewalks, parks, and schools. Risks of government data collection included misuse of the data to limit access to resources or funding and the government exerting more control over the community, such as gerrymandering or police overreach.

When answering these questions, participants struggled to think about personal benefits from the data that the government collects about them. Some of these participants could only think about community-level benefits as opposed to how they benefit directly. When participants could think of individual benefits, they thought about things like government assistance programs, the Department of Motor Vehicles (DMV) or driver's licenses, student loans or financial aid for college, and funding for schools. For example, one participant provided an explanation as to why the individual benefit may not be obvious, suggesting that "[I can think of] benefits in aggregate maybe, like the Census Bureau knowing there are people in this neighborhood who have this median income or x amount of people who don't have health insurance in this area and maybe we can help that. Every benefit I think of comes down to the community level; I probably benefit, but in a very diffuse, hard to quantify way" (P52). In other words, although participants may be able to think of examples around government assistance and allocation of funding, the connection between government data collection and individual benefits can be unclear for those who have not needed government assistance or used other services like public schools.

The questionnaire tested how different stated benefits impacted participants' views on the formation of the Census demographic frame. None of the benefits specifically mention a community impact. However, participants were most likely to think about community impact when discussing the benefit of the database.

Some Spanish-speaking participants had additional and specific concerns regarding whether the government is collecting information about them—that it could potentially be used by immigration enforcement to target them. These participants expressed that the safest thing for them to do would be to not share any information.

English-speaking and Spanish-speaking participants in our study defined community in slightly different ways. Across both groups, participants thought of geographic location as a defining feature of their community. English-speaking participants also included people who receive similar services, such as schools, libraries, or fire departments, many of which are geographically defined. However, Spanish-speaking respondents included their ethnic group as a main feature of their community.

3.2 Varying Perception of Risks and Benefits

Throughout the questionnaire, multiple questions asked participants to weigh the risks and benefits of data collection conducted by companies and the government. They found it easier to consider the risks and benefits of company data collection than government data collection. Overall, participants had a stronger negative reaction to data collection from private companies. They could see and report clear risks of data breaches that might lead to identity theft. Company data breaches are also highly publicized or newsworthy events, and participants were more aware of company data breaches than government data breaches. Similarly, the positives of company data collection were not always clear, which means that participants saw the risks as more substantial because there were no balancing benefits. When participants could think of benefits of company data collection, they thought primarily about targeted ads.

Participants found Question Q4 about the risks versus benefits of company data collection easier to answer than Q8 about government data collection. Similar to the earlier discussion about community benefits and risks being more concrete for participants, participants seemed to have a better understanding and more well-formed opinions about company data collection than government data collection regarding the risks and benefits of both.

When weighing the risks and benefits of government data collection, perception of control seems to mediate feelings. For participants who think they have no control over the data the government collects, the risks and benefits are a moot point, as demonstrated by the comment from P07: “[There are] both benefits and risks and no way to avoid the government getting this information.” As a result, some participants prefer a neutral answer option to be able to report that they view the benefits and risks as equal.

Another finding about risks and benefits is that participants who clearly understood the benefits felt more positively about combining and sharing data. For example, Q18 provided an introduction and then asked: “To what extent are you in favor of or against linking information about individuals?” Participants who were in favor of linking were more often

able to think of clear benefits to linking the data, such as greater efficiency or more accurate statistics. Those who were against data linking failed to see or report any clear benefits.

During the interviews, participants shared a similar reaction to the frame experiment, Q20, as they did to Q18. This question was set up as an experiment to test different statements and how they impact the extent to which respondents are in favor or against the Census Bureau building a database. Different benefits of the database were displayed on this screen, providing different frames around the topic. The frames included filling out surveys less often, helping government agencies make better use of taxpayer money, delivering services and benefits more efficiently, increasing the accuracy of statistics, and completing missing survey responses. The response options asked whether participants were strongly in favor of it, somewhat in favor of it, neither in favor nor against it, somewhat against it, or strongly against it. Participants were first asked about one frame and then about a second frame. They compared the two frames and reported whether their answers would change.

Originally, these statements were expected to be perceived as benefits, and the goal of testing was to investigate how the different benefit framings impact perceptions of the database. However, participants did not always perceive the frame statements as benefits. The first frame (filling out [Census] surveys less often) failed to effectively communicate a benefit to all participants because they are unfamiliar with the other surveys the Census Bureau completes. Because many people only receive the decennial Census survey once every 10 years, filling out surveys less often is not a clear benefit. For example, while comparing the statements between Frame 1 and Frame 2 (making better use of taxpayer money), the comment from P52 states “[Frame 2] gives a clear understanding of the benefit I’d get out of this arrangement as a taxpayer. Makes the advantage much clearer [than Frame 1].”

Although the frame statements were not universally interpreted as benefits as originally intended during the cognitive interview, findings still indicated that the question would meet the research goals of evaluating which statements improve the favorability of the database because the question is able to uncover and compare the varying opinions about these statements.

To further improve Frame 1, a slight wording change was made to make the statement more concrete and expand it from only the Census Bureau to other government surveys. Additionally, the Census Bureau also decided to move forward with an experiment where half of the participants will be presented with a neutral answer option for these risk/benefits questions, which allows the instrument to explore the idea that some participants see the risks and benefits as equal.

3.3 Different Opinions about Data Sharing

Another common theme that emerged from the cognitive interviews is how willing participants are to share different types of data with different entities. Specifically, the testing instrument presented a set of questions (Q12–Q14) asking participants about their willingness to share data with different entities. These included the federal government and participants' state and local governments.

The findings suggest that most participants did not have trouble defining "federal government," but many participants had trouble differentiating clearly between "state" and "local" government. Participants may have different reference points to establish their local government depending on the size of the city (or town) they live in. For example, "local" government could include an entire county for some rural residents but only the township for other rural respondents. Similarly, local government could mean something more localized like a borough or a neighborhood district for some urban residents, while it can mean the city or the general metropolitan area that may overlap multiple counties for other urban respondents.

Although participants might not consistently understand local government when answering the question, they indicated that they were more willing to share data with their local government compared with the federal government, because they believed they could receive more direct benefits. Interestingly, participants also felt positively about filling out the decennial Census for the Census Bureau, reflecting a higher level of trust specifically for the Census Bureau. Taken together, we recommend that these items remain unchanged because the varying definitions of local governments do not seem to prevent participants from forming their opinions about data sharing with different government entities.

Additionally, participants were asked about specific information that the Census Bureau could gather from other agencies, including contact information, occupancy of an address, demographic information, home ownership, income, and number of people in a household (Q23–Q28). When participants were probed further, they indicated that they were also willing to share certain kinds of data but were more hesitant about other data. Participants were willing to share publicly available data, such as voter registration or home ownership; demographic information such as age, gender, or race; and number of people in their household. They are less willing to share income, social security number, and specific employment information such as employer name with the Census Bureau.

Spanish-speaking participants were particularly worried about sharing any personal identifying information like names, addresses, and dates of birth. One Spanish speaker worried about sharing her ethnicity, nationality, and race as well. Given that the study only conducted 15 Spanish interviews, the concerns about sharing ethnicity and nationality may be more prevalent in the wider population.

It is also worth noting that the Spanish interviews have identified one translation issue for further improvement. Ten of 15 Spanish speakers were thinking of identifying information when asked about sharing their data when they read “sus datos” (your data), which is sometimes used colloquially to mean contact information. To reduce the potential confusion, the Census Bureau approved a change to the translation to ask about “datos sobre usted” (data about you).

Finally, another interesting data sharing–related theme that came up across questions is that participants want to explicitly consent to further data sharing. During instrument testing, participants were asked about the extent to which they were in favor of or against combining these data sources (Q17) and the extent to which they were in favor of or against the information they provided for one purpose being used by the government in additional ways (Q21).

Across these questions, participants indicated that their opinion about being in favor or against the item relied on whether they would be able to provide explicit consent at the point of data collection. They wanted to be able to consent for their data to be shared in additional ways and with additional parties beyond when they initially provide it. This sentiment is true both for information provided to the government and to companies, illustrated clearly by the following quotes from the participants. For example, P79 stated “It should be someone's active choice to give that data.” This participant wanted to consent actively to providing data for future uses. Another participant (P18) said “When you’re filling out passport applications for example, is it going to be made clear that that information will be shared with other agencies, or will it just be shared?” This participant wondered whether the people would know that the data shared in one instance would be used elsewhere.

3.4 Unfamiliarity Regarding the Census Bureau’s Function

Consistent with the findings from prior research by the Census Bureau whereby the public may be unfamiliar with what the Census Bureau does outside of the decennial Census, our cognitive interviews also identified the same reaction from participants. For instance, when participants think about data sharing, they were confused about the Census Bureau accessing data that they believed it already has access to through the decennial Census. Some participants believed that the Census Bureau should already have age, contact information, and the number of people in a household. They were confused when questions asked about the Census Bureau retrieving this information from other agencies. One participant said: “Doesn’t the Census already ask [about the number of people in your household]? Am I missing something? I’m for [the Census getting this information] but confused because they already ask this” (P121). Similarly, P52 made the following comment while assessing the Frame 1 (answering government surveys less often): “I’ll have to answer less questions because the Census knows more about me already. Although they only ask questions once a decade so I’m not sure how much less questions they could ask.”

This finding suggests that the public is not acutely aware of other surveys the Census Bureau runs and has not faced the burden of too many surveys.

3.5 Desire for Additional Contextual Information about Survey

The final thematic finding is that participants want more information to inform their response selection. Participants wanted to know more context to better understand the questions to form their opinions given the considerations revolving around privacy and confidentiality. This is also related to the finding that participants are unclear on the Census Bureau's functions.

For example, participants wanted to know more about the purpose and benefits of sharing data between private companies and the Census Bureau. They were unsure why the Census Bureau would need data from private companies and how this could benefit the public in general. Participants reacted negatively to the mention of "private companies." As a result, some participants selected "neither" to reflect their lack of knowledge about the data sharing or the Census Bureau's function when they answered the corresponding questions during the interviews.

Participants also wanted more information about the "additional ways" their data would be shared as mentioned in Q21. The term "additional ways" was described as too vague and hard for participants to understand. Some struggled to make selections because they wanted more information about what additional ways their data would be used by the governments with the information they already provided. For example, P123 said "I would want to know what the new purposes are, more transparency. I would be more in favor if I knew more about how it's being used." This participant expressed that their approval of the database would increase even further if they knew more information. Alternatively, P10 said "I don't know what 'new purposes' means. That's vague. When things are vague, it makes me uncomfortable. Could mean more taxes. Could mean better healthcare. So, not knowing what that is, is terrifying because I don't trust the government at all." This reflects that some people are wary or suspicious of the government, and without additional information, they rely on their overall suspicions to form their opinions.

Still, not all participants who wanted more information answered neither. Those who wanted more information but did not answer "neither" seemed to default to their overall feelings about the topic when they did not have enough information in the question to provide a nuanced answer. In addition, the findings also show that when participants struggled to understand some of the complicated questions in the questionnaire, they sometimes selected the midpoint, "neither in favor nor against it" indicating that it served as a "don't know" option or an indicator for wanting for more information. For example, P18 stated "I don't really know a huge amount about it and what the consequences would be, or even

what the benefit would be. I don't know enough to say either way." This participant selected "neither in favor nor against it" as a result.

In the next chapter, we report the detailed findings of individual questions and their corresponding revision recommendations and the feedback and decisions from the Census Bureau.

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4. Question by Question Findings

This chapter covers specific findings and recommendations made for each question that have not already been discussed in the Overall Themes chapter. It also includes the feedback and revision decisions from the Census Bureau for the corresponding questions when applicable.

Q01

English text

How concerned are you, if at all, about how companies use the data they collect about you?

Spanish text

¿Qué tan preocupado(a) está usted --si lo está-- sobre cómo las compañías usan los datos que obtienen sobre usted?

Table 4-1. Responses to Q01

Response	English n=25	Spanish n=15
Extremely concerned Extremadamente preocupado(a)	4	7
Moderately concerned Moderadamente preocupado(a)	14	6
A little concerned Poco preocupado(a)	4	2
Not at all concerned Para nada preocupado(a)	3	0

Findings (n=40)

Most participants clearly understood this question and thought it was asking them if they were worried about what companies were doing with their data/information (n=28). When asked what they thought companies were doing with their data, participants mentioned sharing or selling their information with other companies (n=18) and marketing or targeted ads (n=17).

Very few participants misinterpreted this question. One participant thought “companies” was referring to companies that people work for or are applying to work for. One participant thought about government involvement in collecting and sharing/selling information. Similarly, two participants thought about the Census Bureau when answering this question, perhaps because of the context of participating in an interview for the Census Bureau. One

participant commented that she did not understand the question at first and was only able to answer when she remembered the questions she was asked in screening as context.

Although most participants understood the question, some participants indicated that some of the question terms are vague, or they wanted more information to inform their answer. More specifically, two participants reported that their answers would depend on what kind of data, two participants said their responses depend on what the company is doing with the data, and two participants said their answers depend on the company. For example, one participant commented, "I don't think people would be concerned over companies using their data to give them a better customer experience. They'd be more concerned about misuse and abuse." In addition, one participant commented that they would prefer the first response option to say, "A lot" instead of "Extremely." Lastly, three participants felt that there was not anything they could do about companies using their data. For example, one participant commented, "I feel the companies will have info on you regardless of what you do. The data we have on us may be misused. It can be dangerous."

Recommendations

Overall: Few Issues

Because most participants did not have difficulties with understanding and answering this question, no revisions were recommended. However, see Q05 for a discussion of the scale used in this question.

Census feedback

See Q05 for a discussion of changes implemented to the scale.

Q02*English text*

How much do you feel you personally benefit, if at all, from the data that companies collect about you?

Spanish text

¿Cuánto siente usted que se beneficia personalmente --si es que se beneficia-- de los datos que las compañías obtienen sobre usted?

Table 4-2. Responses to Q02

Response	English n=25	Spanish n=15
Benefit a great deal Me beneficio mucho	2	0
Benefit some Me beneficio algo	12	2
Benefit very little Me beneficio muy poco	8	2
Do not benefit No me beneficio	3	11

Findings (n=40)

Most participants did not have trouble understanding the term “personally benefit” as intended. However, there were some differences in interpretation across English- and Spanish-speaking participants. When asked for examples of benefits, English-speaking participants mentioned examples such as targeted advertisements or improving the consumer experience (n=10), online search optimization (n=4), saving money (n=6) and time (n=3), algorithms predicting what users like (n=2), and autofill forms (n=2). For example, one participant commented, “My search optimization is better or lots of sneaky little things happening behind the scenes that help me use the internet more efficiently and sell me more things.” Many Spanish-speaking participants, however, seemed to think of “beneficios” more narrowly and only included material benefits, rather than including some of the less tangible benefits provided as examples by English-speaking participants. For example, participants mentioned supplies provided to those in need by a non-profit, such as food. In addition, two Spanish-speaking participants seemed to associate the term “beneficia” specifically with financial and material assistance or welfare, as opposed to the more general understanding demonstrated by most English-speaking participants. Last, when providing examples of companies that collect data, some Spanish-speaking participants did not differentiate between private companies and government entities while answering this question.

Notably, 10 participants across both languages were not sure how they could personally benefit or did not think they personally benefitted at all.

Participants were asked about the use of the word “feel” in this question and whether they thought “feel” and “think” were asking about a different concept. More specifically, 16 participants said there was no difference between “think” and “feel” while 16 participants said there was a difference between “think” and “feel”, but some of these participants struggled to verbalize the difference or noted that the difference was small or negligible. Participants were also asked if their answer would change if this question used the word “think” instead of “feel” and three participants said they would change their answer in this case. One of these participants answered, “Benefit some” with the original question wording of “feel,” but said they would answer “Benefit very little” if the question said “think” because they said that “think” indicated to them more rational thought and “feel” was more about emotions. Another one of these participants answered, “Do not benefit” with the original question wording of “feel,” but said they would answer “Benefit very little” if the question said “think” because they thought more about rewards. The third participant said when she reads “cuánto creo” she would like to see a pamphlet with an explanation of the benefits; she said when she is asked “how she feels” she answers based on her emotions and the answers were biased by her feelings. In addition, three Spanish-speaking participants had a hard time understanding the probe about thinking versus feeling and were unable to answer. In summary, although participants were split on whether they thought “think” and “feel” mean different things or not, most participants (n=24) said they would not change their answer if the question asked “think” instead of “feel.” Overall, findings indicate that changing the question wording to “think” instead of “feel” would result in no change in the cognitive process that respondents are using to provide a response.

Other findings from cognitive testing include the following: one participant noted that they would prefer that the first response option said, “Benefit a good amount” instead of “Benefit a great deal,” and two participants mentioned that they were not sure what happens with the data that are collected about them.

Recommendations

Overall: Some Issues

In English, participants understand “think” and “feel” as interchangeable and findings indicate that this wording does not impact their response choice. However, there are some significant issues in Spanish, with several Spanish speakers limiting their consideration of benefits to financial or material benefits. Changing the Spanish translation might help address this, but it cannot be confirmed whether alternative translations used will resolve this issue without further testing. However, we believe that “obtener ventajas” as opposed to “beneficiarse” could reduce the association with benefits in the sense of financial

assistance and welfare and help respondents think more generally about benefits beyond material and financial help.

Revision suggestion for Spanish

¿Qué tantas ventajas siente usted que tiene personalmente --si las tiene-- de los datos que las compañías obtienen sobre usted?

- Muchas ventajas
- Algunas ventajas
- Muy pocas ventajas
- Ninguna ventaja

Census feedback

The Spanish translation of Q02 will not be changed. The language team was concerned that the suggested revision altered the question too significantly and would be back-translated as “How many advantages do you feel you personally have, if at all, from the data that companies collect about you?” The language team worried that the changes to the question text and response options (i.e., “Many advantages”, “Some advantages”) would be too dissimilar to the English version. They recommended further testing of alternative wording options.

Q03*English text*

How much control do you feel you have, if any, over the data that companies collect about you?

Spanish text

¿Cuánto control siente usted que tiene --si es que lo tiene-- sobre los datos que las compañías obtienen sobre usted?

Table 4-3. Responses to Q03

Response	English n=25	Spanish n=15
A great deal of control Mucho control	3	1
Some control Algo de control	6	7
Very little control Muy poco control	15	2
No control Ningún control	1	5

Findings (n=40)

When asked what kinds of data they were thinking about while answering this question, participants mentioned examples such as demographics or contact information (n=21), Internet/shopping activity (n=11), income/financial data (n=7), social media (n=5), medical records (n=5), map/location data (n=4), and employment history (n=3). When asked what kinds of companies they were thinking about, participants mentioned tech companies such as Facebook (n=6), Amazon/Alexa (n=4), Google (n=4), Uber (n=1), and Apple/Android (n=1); retail stores, such as Target (n=1), CVS (n=1), and clothing stores in general (n=1); insurance companies (n=3); credit card companies (n=2); government agencies, such as the Internal Revenue Services (IRS) (n=1), the DMV (n=1), and city financial assistance (n=1); wireless and Internet carriers (n=5); and banks and loan companies (n=5).

When discussing what they were thinking about while answering this question, some participants mentioned privacy settings on websites, apps, or social media accounts. More specifically, participants were split on whether they believed they could control their data through privacy settings. Only one participant believed that these privacy settings are in the user's control, explaining, "Companies allow you to customize the information they collect on you. You can make Google not use your information; same for Facebook." In contrast,

five participants commented that users have some control over these privacy settings but not a lot, and three participants thought that users cannot control privacy settings. For example, one participant commented, "I came to this answer because sometimes if you want something, I want to do X, Y, Z online I am in a bind. I have to give a company some information about myself in order to access the product or service or whatever. I don't have much control over the data." Another participant commented, "Specifically, the cookies notification that has been mandatory the last few months, that companies are using cookies and what they're using your information for. On some websites I do have control, but some there is no option of turning that off and you have to accept the cookie settings in order to use the website. I feel like I have very little control because it's on a website by website or company by company basis on how they're collecting my information." Last, three participants also mentioned that they felt they were not knowledgeable on this subject.

Recommendations

Overall: Few Issues

Because most participants did not have difficulties with understanding and answering this question, no revisions were recommended.

Census feedback

None.

Q04

English text

Which of the following statements comes the closest to your opinion?

Spanish text

¿Cuál de las siguientes afirmaciones se acerca más a su opinión?

Table 4-4. Responses to Q04

Response	English n=25	Spanish n=15
The benefits I get from companies collecting data about me are greater than the risks Los beneficios que recibo de que las compañías obtengan datos sobre mí son mayores que los riesgos	14	2
The risks of companies collecting data about me are greater than the benefits I get Los riesgos que trae que las compañías obtengan datos sobre mí son mayores que los beneficios que recibo	11	9
Did not ask	—	4

Findings of common themes (n=36)

When thinking about benefits, participants thought about examples such as targeted online ads (n=7), coupons or promotions (n=6), credit card points or cash back (n=1), search optimization (n=1), communications from companies (n=1), saving account information for easy check out (n=1), and taking medical records from one doctor to another (n=1). Notably, six participants were unable to think of any benefits of company data collection.

For risks, participants primarily thought about data breaches leading to compromised data and possible identity theft (n=19) and information being sold without consent (e.g., phone number, email; n=11). For example, one participant commented, "It's more about that they can't guarantee anonymity. Whatever they collect on me, if they were to be hacked, then my information would be out there for other or unknown purposes. Such information would be my cell phone number, so then I get calls from telemarketers, or my home address, where we could be targeted for package theft." Notably, two participants could think of no risks.

Although answering this question was straightforward and clear for most participants, one preferred a "no opinion" option.

Findings related to moving the question

As mentioned on p. 2-4, this question was presented as the fourth question in the survey for 18 English-speaking participants and 7 Spanish-speaking participants. During cognitive interview data collection, questions asking about the benefits of data collection, including this question, were moved so that they were asked after Q22; seven English-speaking participants and 8 Spanish-speaking participants saw the survey in this new order. The order was changed because respondents struggled to answer these questions without additional context when they were asked in their original positions and were moved because Q17–Q22 provided some examples of benefits of government data collection. For Q4, in the original position, three participants mentioned government data when answering. After being moved, three participants said that they thought about government data collection instead of company data collection.

Recommendations

Overall: Few Issues

The topic of company data collection was fairly clear for participants, who did not struggle significantly to provide responses. There are no recommendations to change the wording of this question in English. However, we recommend moving forward with placing this question with the other company questions (Q1–Q3) because of topic. When moved later in the survey, participants often missed that this question was about company data collection. In addition, we may want to consider adjusting the translation of this question based on findings in other questions regarding the interpretation of “beneficios” in Spanish.

Revision suggestion for Spanish

¿Cuál de las siguientes afirmaciones se acerca más a su opinión?

- Las **ventajas** que recibo de que las compañías obtengan datos sobre mí son mayores que los **riesgos**
- Los **riesgos** que trae que las compañías obtengan datos sobre mí son mayores que las **ventajas** que recibo

Census feedback

Q04 will be kept in the original placement at the beginning of the questionnaire in the final version. For the national data collection, we will conduct a survey experiment with two experimental conditions using two different sets of response options. Treatment A consists of the original two response options listed above. Treatment B consists of the following three options:

English text

- The **benefits** I get from companies collecting data about me are greater than the **risks**

- The **benefits** and **risks** from companies collecting data about me are the same
- The **risks** of companies collecting data about me are greater than the **benefits** I get

Spanish text

- Los beneficios que recibo de que las compañías obtengan datos sobre mí son mayores que los **riesgos**
- Hay tantos **beneficios** como **riesgos** de que las compañías obtengan datos sobre mí
- Los **riesgos** que trae que las compañías obtengan datos sobre mí son mayores que los **beneficios** que recibo

Q05*English text*

How concerned are you, if at all, about how the government is using the data it collects about you?

Spanish text

¿Qué tan preocupado(a) está --si es que lo está-- de cómo el gobierno está usando los datos que obtiene sobre usted?

Table 4-5. Responses to Q05

Response	English n=25	Spanish n=15
Extremely concerned Extremadamente preocupado(a)	6	4
Moderately concerned Moderadamente preocupado(a)	7	6
A little concerned Poco preocupado(a)	6	3
Not at all concerned Para nada preocupado(a)	6	2

Findings (n=40)

When asked about what kind of data they thought about while answering this question, participants were split on thinking about actual data the government has and other kinds of data outside of government purview. Some examples of identified data that the government does have access to included social security number (n=11); tax records or financial data (n=12); demographics, including gender and ethnicity (n=6); driver's license information (n=4), contact information, such as address (n=12); personally identifiable information, such as name and date of birth (n=12); voter registration (n=2); the number of people in a household (n=3); employment information (n=2); and data shared when applying for a city financial assistance program (n=1). Some examples of other data that participants considered that are outside of government purview included medical or health records (n=4); any Internet actions, such as search history (n=2); and communication monitoring, such as access to text message, phone calls, or general monitoring of activity on devices (n=3). Notably, two participants struggled to think of any examples of data collected by the government. Although the examples of types of data were similar across English- and Spanish-speaking participants, two Spanish-speaking participants spoke about their immigration status and how it played into their thinking as they answered the question.

Two participants were torn between selecting moderately and extremely concerned. One of these participants specifically stated they wanted an answer option in between moderately and extremely concerned. This participant interpreted moderately as “somewhat” and said that did not fit the response they wanted to provide. The other participant also struggled to choose between moderately and extremely concerned. This participant interpreted moderately as “very” concerned.

Although there was no direct probe about how the government is using the data it collects, some participants spontaneously provided further information. Three participants said they were not sure what the government does with the data it collects. Two of these participants were able to give concrete examples of data the government has but were unsure what was done with the data. For example, one participant commented, “I understand and accept that data is collected about myself. What do they do with it? I have no idea. I’m concerned about what will be done with that information down the road.” Furthermore, five participants said that they believe that the government uses data to track criminals or identify people who are committing crimes. Last, two participants admitted this was not something they think much about, leading them to answer not at all concerned and a little concerned.

Recommendations

Overall: Some Issues

Findings indicate that some participants misunderstood the data that the government has access to, but this reflects their overall knowledge about the topic in general. Those who responded “Extremely concerned” more commonly reported extraneous data when probed about examples of data that the government collects during the interview.

Findings also indicate that there were some issues with the response scale. Participants seemed to understand “moderately” in different ways and prefer to have a response option in-between “moderately” and “extremely.” We should consider changing the wording of “moderately” to another more consistently understood word, such as “somewhat.” If we do change the scale for Q5, the same changes should be implemented on the complementary question about companies (Q1), and other questions that use this scale (Q36, Q38). For Q1, one participant took issue with the response option “extremely concerned” and preferred “a lot concerned.” This response to the scale provides further evidence that the scale is not working well across questions and may need to be tweaked. Because of the issues discovered in Q1 around “extremely” concerned and the suggestion to change “moderately” to “somewhat,” we recommend changing the first response option to “very” concerned. The distance between “somewhat” and “extremely” is likely too large given the other scale items.

Revision suggestions

How concerned are you, if at all, about how the government is using the data it collects about you?

- Very concerned
- Somewhat concerned
- A little concerned
- Not at all concerned

Census feedback

The scale options used in Q05 will be implemented consistently across the final instrument.

Q06*English text*

How much, if at all, do you feel you personally benefit from the data the government collects about you?

Spanish text

¿Cuánto siente usted que se beneficia personalmente --si es que se beneficia-- de los datos que el gobierno obtiene sobre usted?

Table 4-6. Responses to Q06

Response	English n=25	Spanish n=15
Benefit a great deal Me beneficio mucho	4	6
Benefit some Me beneficio algo	7	5
Benefit very little Me beneficio muy poco	7	3
No benefit No me beneficio	6	1
No answer	1	0

Findings (n=40)

Participants were asked about the possible benefits of the government collecting data, and several participants struggled to think of any benefits (n=10). Of those participants, a few struggled to think of ways they personally benefit (n=2). They thought of examples of community benefits, such as funding for public schools or financial aid for college, but these things did not benefit them personally. Some participants explained that there were no benefits (n=6), while one participant could only think of a scenario where she might want a government job, like becoming a teacher, and would benefit from the government knowing she is not in tax debt and give her the job.

When participants could think of examples of benefits, they included government assistance programs, such as social security, Medicare, housing support, welfare, unemployment payments, and SNAP and CHIP (n=15); funding decisions or allocation of funds (n=5); DMV records or driver's licenses (n=3); student loans or financial aid for college (n=4); funding for schools (n=2); stimulus payments (n=2); and one each for emergency preparedness, generating statistics about the community that could be used in one's work, and making it easier to vote.

Other comments received by participants include one from a participant who believes the government already has access to data collected by private companies, and two participants who discussed the government uses data it has to collect taxes and assess property values, which they both saw as negatives.

Recommendations

Overall: Some Issues

When participants could not think of any examples of benefits, they most commonly answered “No benefit.” The “No benefit” response may better reflect lack of knowledge of benefits and respondents who are uninformed about the topic in general, rather than respondents thinking there truly are no benefits. We may want to consider a “Don’t know” response option to capture respondents’ poor understanding of the topic more accurately.

Alternatively, this question could be a candidate for removal, especially considering the large number of questions about benefits. When reviewing Q8 (personal risks and benefits question), one participant indicated they thought Q8 and Q6 were asking about the same topic. Furthermore, some participants struggle to think about personal benefits and opinions may be better captured by the community benefits questions (Q9).

If changes to the Spanish translation of Q2 are implemented, they should be changed here as well.

Revision suggestions

English text

How much, if at all, do you feel you personally benefit from the data the government collects about you?

- Benefit a great deal
- Benefit some
- Benefit very little
- No benefit

Spanish text

¿Qué tantas ventajas siente usted que tiene personalmente --si las tiene-- de los datos que el gobierno obtiene sobre usted?

- Muchas ventajas
- Algunas ventajas
- Muy pocas ventajas
- Ninguna ventaja

Census feedback

The “Don’t know” option will not be necessary for the scale options used in Q06 for both languages for the final instrument.

Q07*English text*

How much control do you feel you have, if any, over the data that the government collects about you?

Spanish text

¿Cuánto control siente usted que tiene --si es que lo tiene-- sobre los datos que el gobierno obtiene sobre usted?

Table 4-7. Responses to Q07

Response	English n=25	Spanish n=15
A great deal of control Mucho control	2	1
Some control Algo de control	4	3
Very little control Muy poco control	13	6
No control Ningún control	6	5

Findings (n=40)

There were no scripted probes for this question, and no question issues were identified from the spontaneous feedback for this question. However, some participants brought up interesting points about the topic of government data collection. A few participants said that giving the government data is required to function in society (n=3). One participant explained, "You need to provide data to do everyday life things, like get a job with a social security number or drive a car."

A few participants reflected on how little control they have over how the government uses the data. Two participants felt they have very little control over the data the government collects, while two other participants felt control mattered at the point of data collection, such as when filling out surveys. One participant felt she could not skip survey questions on the Census or DMV applications; however, another thought that someone could answer untruthfully on the Census, giving them more control over the data the government collects. Another few participants brought up concerns about not knowing what kind of data the government collects (n=2), with one of the participants explaining that he could not change the data the government already has, giving him very little control over it.

Recommendations

Overall: Few Issues

No revision suggestions.

Census feedback

None.

Q08*English text*

Which of the following statements comes the closest to your opinion?

Spanish text

¿Cuál de las siguientes afirmaciones se acerca más a su opinión?

Table 4-8. Responses to Q08

Response	English n=25	Spanish n=15
The benefits the government can provide by collecting data about me are greater than the risks Los beneficios que el gobierno puede proporcionar al obtener datos sobre mí son mayores que los riesgos	15	3
The risks of the government collecting data about me are greater than the benefits it can provide Los riesgos de que el gobierno obtenga datos sobre mí son mayores que los beneficios que eso puede proporcionar	8	8
No answer	2	4

Findings Overall (n=40)

Throughout the interviews, we found that answering this question about the government was more difficult for participants than the complementary question about companies. Some participants struggled to choose between the two options (n=4). One participant would choose “not sure” if that answer option was available, while three participants preferred an equal or neutral option reflecting that the benefits and risks are the same. Of those three participants, a few explained that there was no way to control the data that the government has, which impacted their request for a neutral option. Perception of control seems to mediate feeling about risks and benefits (n=2). One participant commented, “There’s both benefits and risks and no way to avoid government getting this information.”

Although there was no direct probe about what “risks” means, three participants spontaneously volunteered their understanding. They thought primarily about information being compromised and used in nefarious ways. Two participants could not think of any risks. Another participant thought this question was redundant with Q6 (How much, if at all, do you feel you personally benefit from the data the government collects about you?). This participant used their response to Q6 to inform their answer choice to Q8.

A few Spanish-speaking participants had a hard time answering the question and had to re-read it several times (n=3). As experienced in Q2, some Spanish-speaking participants were thinking very narrowly about benefits and strongly associating the term with government assistance (n=2). A few other Spanish-speaking participants thought that Q8 was the same as Q4 (n=2). However, one later realized the difference.

One participant believed that the government already has access to data collected by private companies. Two participants explained that the government uses the data it has to collect taxes and assess property values, which they both saw as negatives.

Findings – original position (n=25)

Two participants formed their answer based directly on a comparison to the risks and benefits provided by company data collection.

Findings – moved after Q22 (n=15)

We hoped that moving the question would help participants think about benefits of government data collection more easily. However, there was still one participant who was unable to decide on an answer.

Recommendations

Overall: Some Issues

Although moving this question did not result in significant differences in responses, the sample size was small (n=15). We recommend leaving Q08 in this position after Q22 because there were no problems identified with this placement and the information in the proceeding questions may provide useful context.

We should further discuss whether we want to include a neutral answer option or a “Don’t know” option. Four participants struggled to decide which answer to choose, with two ultimately refusing to provide an answer. If we move to the full survey with the question as it is, item nonresponse may be a concern.

Based on findings in other questions regarding the interpretation of “beneficios” in Spanish, we may want to consider adjusting the translation of this question as well.

Revision Suggestions

English text

Which of the following statements comes the closest to your opinion?

- The **benefits** the government can provide by collecting data **about me** are greater than the **risks**
- The **benefits** and **risks** of the government collecting data **about me** are the same

- The **risks** of the government collecting data **about me** are greater than the **benefits** it can provide

Spanish text (for both two and three options)

¿Cuál de las siguientes afirmaciones se acerca más a su opinión?

- Los **beneficios** que el gobierno puede proporcionar al obtener datos **sobre mí** son mayores que los **riesgos**
- Hay tantos **beneficios** como **riesgos** de que el gobierno obtenga datos **sobre mí**
- Los **riesgos** de que el gobierno obtenga datos sobre mí son mayores que los **beneficios** que eso puede proporcionar

¿Cuál de las siguientes afirmaciones se acerca más a su opinión?

- Los **beneficios** que el gobierno puede proporcionar al obtener datos **sobre mí** son mayores que los **riesgos**
- Los **riesgos** de que el gobierno obtenga datos **sobre mí** son mayores que los **beneficios** que eso puede proporcionar

Census feedback

Q08 will be kept in the original placement of the questionnaire as intended in the final version. For the national data collection, we will conduct a survey experiment with two experimental conditions using two different sets of response options. Treatment A consists of the original two response options with the suggested revision for the Spanish version. Treatment B consists of the three options listed above. As detailed in Q02, no changes will be made to the Spanish translation of “benefits.”

Q09*English text*

How much, if at all, do you feel your community benefits from the data the government collects about you?

Spanish text

¿Cuánto siente usted que su comunidad se beneficia --si es que se beneficia-- de los datos que el gobierno obtiene sobre usted?

Table 4-9. Responses to Q09

Response	English n=25	Spanish n=15
Benefit a great deal Se beneficio mucho	4	2
Benefit some Se beneficio algo	13	6
Benefit very little Se beneficio muy poco	4	2
No benefit No me beneficio	4	5

Findings (n=40)

Overall, participants did not have difficulty in defining what “community” means to them. Most participants defined community as their neighborhood (n=16), their city (n=9), their town (n=6), their ethnic group (i.e., the Latino community) (n=4), or their county (n=2). Some participants defined it as a geographic area, without giving more specific details (n=12), while others also considered a similar group of people who receive similar services, such as schools, libraries, or the fire department (n=6).

Only one participant considered online groups as part of a community, but they noted it depends on “what you do online.” Another participant defined their community specifically as the people living in their large housing development.

When asked whether participants were thinking about data about individual people or data about communities, participants were split. Several participants said they were thinking about data about people (n=17), while some participants said they were thinking about both, explaining that individuals make up a community (n=11). The last group of five participants said they were thinking about data about the community.

Most participants did not have trouble providing examples of benefits to the community. Several participants mentioned allocation of funding/resources for social support services

(n=16). Others mentioned similar improvements to the community, like building/fixing sidewalks, parks, or funding for schools (n=12), and another six participants could not think of any benefits to the community.

One participant commented that they were not sure which level of government this question was asking about. One participant said the question was vague. Another participant thought the question was confusing and did not understand the relationship between her personal data and benefits for her community.

Recommendations

Overall: Few Issues

Per findings in previous questions (such as Q06), the current translation of “benefits” may be misunderstood. We recommend adjusting the question text and answer options to match previous recommendations.

Revision Suggestions

Spanish text

¿En qué medida siente usted que su comunidad tiene ventajas --si es que las tiene-- de los datos que el gobierno obtiene sobre usted?

- Muchas ventajas
- Algunas ventajas
- Muy pocas ventajas
- Ninguna ventaja

Census feedback

As detailed in Q02, no changes will be made to the Spanish translation of “benefits.”

Q10*English text*

Do you believe government data collection can harm your community?

Spanish text

¿Cree usted que la recolección de datos por parte del gobierno pueda perjudicar a su comunidad?

Table 4-10. Responses to Q10

Response	English n=25	Spanish n=15
Yes Sí	12	4
No No	13	10
No answer	0	1

Findings (n=40)

In general, participants did not have difficulty coming up with examples of how government data collection can harm their community. Some participants mentioned limited access to resources or funding as an example of harm (n=11). Another example that participants provided was the government making decisions that could harm their community (n=7). Other participants mentioned examples of the government exerting more control over the community or infringing on their rights, such as gerrymandering, police overreach, immigration enforcement, and redlining (n=9), while some participants could not think of any examples of harm from government data collection (n=7).

One participant, however, was thinking of individual harm and not harm to the community. Her example was that someone's bank account number could be exposed and stolen. When the word community was pointed out, she just said that the way she saw it was that everyone in the community would have access to others' sensitive private information.

Additional findings included a few participants who wanted a "Don't know" or "Not sure" option (n=2) and some participants (n=3) who did not like the word "harm." One participant explained that the word "harm" feels "harsh." One participant suggested replacing the word "harm" with "control or attack in a mild form." Another participant said that they were having a tough time with the word "harm" because "harm" to them means "hurtful, injury like a broken arm or black eye," explaining, "harm has to occur, and you have to see the results of it for it to be categorized as harm."

Recommendations

Overall: Few Issues

Consistent with the recommendations from the expert review, some participants struggled with the word “harm.” However, most were able to think of examples of harm to their communities and all participants provided a response.

Revision Suggestions

- No revisions recommended.

Census feedback

None.

Q11

English text

Which of the following statements comes the closest to your opinion?

Spanish text

¿Cuál de las siguientes afirmaciones se acerca más a su opinión?

Table 4-11. Responses to Q11

Response	English n=25	Spanish n=15
The benefits the government can provide by collecting data about my community are greater than the risks Los beneficios que el gobierno puede proporcionar al obtener datos sobre mi comunidad son mayores que los riesgos	12	7
The risks of the government collecting data about my community are greater than the benefits it can provide Los riesgos de que el gobierno obtenga datos sobre mi comunidad son mayores que los beneficios que eso puede proporcionar	13	3
No answer	1	5

Overall findings (n=40)

Participants were asked to provide examples of “benefits” as used in this question. The participants provided similar responses as asked in Q9 (How much, if at all, do you feel your community benefits from the data the government collects about you?). Several participants mentioned funding for services and improvements to the community (n=18). A few participants provided examples of public health, especially during COVID (n=4). A few other participants could not think of any examples of benefits (n=3).

When asked to provide examples of “risks,” participants provided similar responses as provided for Q10 (Do you believe government data collection can harm your community?). A few participants gave examples of higher taxes or financial risks (n=4). A few provided examples of no funding or reduced access to resources (n=4). Some mentioned the potential for inaccurate data or misinterpretation of the data (n=3). Some said that the government could use personal information to identify undocumented immigrants (n=3), and one participant said their data could be misused by politicians. Another five participants could not think of any examples of risks.

One participant suggested another response option for “risks and benefits are equal”; this participant did not provide a response to the survey question.

Findings: Original Position (n=18) vs. Moved after Q22 (n=7)

There were no unique findings for this question based on the placement.

Recommendations

Overall: Few Issues

This question is triggering similar examples and thought processes for participants when compared to Q9 and Q10. We may want to consider removal of one or more of the community benefits questions because of an overlap in concepts.

Community benefits and risks seem more concrete for participants than individual or personal benefits. The findings from this question continue to support possible removal of one or more of the questions about personal benefits (Q6–Q8). Per comments from Census on July 18, 2022, Q6 (How much, if at all, do you feel you personally benefit from the data the government collects about you?) is a candidate for deletion as long as questions about community benefits are included.

Per findings in previous questions, the current translation of “benefits” may be misunderstood. We recommend adjusting the answer options to match previous recommendations.

Revision Suggestions

English text

Which of the following statements comes the closest to your opinion?

- The **benefits** the government can provide by collecting data about my **community** are greater than the **risks**
- The **benefits** and **risks** of the government collecting data about my **community** are the same
- The **risks** of the government collecting data about my **community** are greater than the **benefits** it can provide

Spanish text (for both two and three options)

¿Cuál de las siguientes afirmaciones se acerca más a su opinión?

- Los **riesgos** de que el gobierno obtenga datos sobre mi **comunidad** son mayores que los **beneficios** que eso puede proporcionar

¿Cuál de las siguientes afirmaciones se acerca más a su opinión?

- Los **beneficios** que el gobierno puede proporcionar al obtener datos sobre mi **comunidad** son mayores que los **riesgos**
- Los **riesgos** de que el gobierno obtenga datos sobre mi **comunidad** son mayores que los **beneficios** que eso puede proporcionar

Census feedback

Q11 will be kept in the original placement of the questionnaire as intended in the final version. For the national data collection, we will conduct a survey experiment with two experimental conditions using two different sets of response options. Treatment A consists of the original two response options with the suggested revision for the Spanish version. Treatment B consists of the three options listed above. As detailed in Q02, no changes will be made to the Spanish translation of “benefits.”

Q12

Consistent with the question presentation during the cognitive interviews, Questions 12, 13, and 14 were analyzed together.

English text

How willing are you to share your data with the **federal** government?

Spanish text

¿Qué tan dispuesto(a) está usted a compartir sus datos con el gobierno **federal**?

Table 4-12. Responses to Q12

Response	English n=25	Spanish n=15
Very willing Muy dispuesto(a)	6	7
Moderately willing Moderadamente dispuesto(a)	9	6
Slightly willing Poco dispuesto(a)	6	1
Not at all willing Para nada dispuesto(a)	4	1

Q13

English text

How willing are you to share your data with your **state** government?

Spanish text

¿Qué tan dispuesto(a) está a compartir sus datos con el gobierno de su **estado**?

Table 4-13. Responses to Q13

Response	English n=25	Spanish n=15
Very willing Muy dispuesto(a)	7	7
Moderately willing Moderadamente dispuesto(a)	10	7
Slightly willing Poco dispuesto(a)	3	1
Not at all willing Para nada dispuesto(a)	5	0

Q14*English text*How willing are you to share your data with your **local** government?*Spanish text*¿Qué tan dispuesto(a) está a compartir sus datos con su gobierno **local**?**Table 4-14. Responses to Q14**

Response	English n=25	Spanish n=15
Very willing Muy dispuesto(a)	9	7
Moderately willing Moderadamente dispuesto(a)	9	6
Slightly willing Poco dispuesto(a)	3	2
Not at all willing Para nada dispuesto(a)	4	0

Findings (n=40)

In general, participants did not have trouble understanding “federal government.” Participants considered the following: federal government was the highest level of government (n=6); specific politicians, such as the president or vice president (n=6); and Capitol Hill/Washington D.C. (n=2). Another three participants thought of senators, governors, and Congress.

Participants provided the following examples of specific federal government agencies or institutions: Census Bureau (n=4); IRS (n=3); Social Security (n=2); NIH (n=1); FBI, CIA, and ATF (n=1); the U.S. Postal Service (n=1); the Supreme Court (n=1); the Department of Agriculture, the Department of Commerce, and the Department of Defense (n=1); and the Department of Education (n=1).

In general, participants saw some overlap between state and local government and sometimes could not articulate the difference. In defining “state government,” several participants could not define this further beyond “my state” (n=15). A few participants mentioned specific politicians or roles, such as judges (n=1), senators (n=1), governors (n=4), or state House of Representatives (n=1). In defining “local government,” participants often mentioned city/city council/city hall (n=6), the mayor (n=8), the county or town (n=8), or the police/sheriff department (n=1). However, another 10 participants were not sure what “local government” meant and had difficulty defining this. Two Spanish speaking participants were not clear on the difference between the federal and state governments.

Participants could easily list examples of data they were thinking about while answering these questions but could not easily place these data at the different levels of federal, state, and local government. Some common examples of data included income taxes/income/financial data (n=13); information collected by the DMV, like vehicle registration and driver’s license (n=6); household composition (n=6); voter registration (n=4); employment history (n=5); and personally identifiable information like name, contact information, DOB, address, or SSN (n=14). Several participants were more willing to share some types of data than others, especially general information (such as demographic data) (n=8). However, one participant said that she was less willing to share her ethnicity, nationality, or race.

Overall, participants are more willing to share data with their local government than federal government, because they believe they can receive more direct benefits (n=8). However, five participants noted that they are more willing to share data with the Census Bureau/fill out the Census.

English and Spanish participants had different reactions to sharing data with the federal government. Some English participants assumed that some federal data was already being collected and shared—that some of this was out of their control (n=6). Two Spanish participants were more willing to share some information with federal government compared to state/local. One participant was more willing to share information with the federal government because they saw the state and local governments as more corrupt and less reliable. Another participant was also more willing to share sensitive information, like SSN, with the federal government than with state or local governments. She explained this was because she had worked as a Census enumerator and saw the seriousness with which

data are protected and how data are handled. One participant said she would be willing to share any data if needed to receive any benefits from social programs.

Three participants changed their answers during the think aloud process or during probing, wanting to better reflect their comparative willingness to share data across the three levels of government. Two participants decided to change their answers after they thought through what the constructs of "federal" and "state" meant to them, specifically when comparing these two. One participant changed their answer to "moderately" instead of "slightly" for local, wanting to show that they are more willing to share at the local level compared to the federal and state level because to them "local" is associated with their community.

Recommendations

Overall: Some Issues

Most participants did not have trouble defining "federal government," but many participants had trouble differentiating between "state" and "local" government. In addition, most participants could not place examples of data being collected about them at the federal, state, or local level. One reason for this may be that participants have different reference points to establish their local government depending on the size of the city (or town) they live in. For example, "local" government could include an entire county for some rural residents but only the township for other rural respondents. Similarly, local government could mean something more localized like a borough or a neighborhood district for some urban residents, while for other urban respondents it can mean the city or the general metropolitan area that may overlap multiple counties.

Because of the issues distinguishing between local and state governments and the different types of data available to both, we recommend collapsing these government types (i.e., Q13 and Q14) into one single question, presented below. We also recommend no changes to Q12 about federal government.

Because 10 of the 15 Spanish speakers thought of identifying information when asked about what data they were considering (when only four English speakers did the same), we believe there may be a translation issue at work. "Sus datos" is sometimes used colloquially to mean personal info or contact info. We believe a small change to the translation of asking about "datos sobre usted" (data about you) could minimize this, but it is of course not possible to know for sure without testing. There is also a possibility that because of the generally lower education levels of the Spanish speakers in the sample, they may simply be less familiar with as many types of data as the English speakers. Either way, we do not believe the change will impair understanding.

Spanish Revision Suggestions

¿Qué tan dispuesto(a) está usted a compartir datos sobre usted con el gobierno **federal**?

- Muy dispuesto(a)
- Algo dispuesto(a)
- Un poquito dispuesto(a)
- Para nada dispuesto(a)

¿Qué tan dispuesto(a) está a compartir datos sobre usted con el gobierno de su **estado**?

¿Qué tan dispuesto(a) está a compartir datos sobre usted con su gobierno **local**?

Census feedback

The Census Bureau is going to keep the three levels of government question as originally intended. Based on current events, this distinction is even more important. Additionally, the Census Bureau approved the recommended revision for Spanish for Q12, Q13, and Q14.

Q15

Consistent with the question presentation during the cognitive interviews, Questions 15 and 16 were analyzed together.

English text

Do you think federal government agencies share a single central database of the name, address, and date of birth of U.S. residents?

Spanish text

¿Cree usted que las agencias del gobierno federal comparten una sola base de datos central que contiene el nombre, la dirección y la fecha de nacimiento de las personas que viven en los Estados Unidos?

Table 4-15. Responses to Q15

Response	English n=11	Spanish n=2
Yes Sí	6	1
No No	5	1

Q16

English text

Do you think that federal government agencies **should** share a single central database of the name, address, and date of birth of U.S. residents?

Spanish text

¿Cree usted que las agencias del gobierno federal **deberían** compartir una sola base de datos central, con el nombre, la dirección y la fecha de nacimiento de las personas que viven en los Estados Unidos?

Table 4-16. Responses to Q16

Response	English n=11	Spanish n=2
Yes Sí	6	2
No No	5	0

Findings (n=13)

When asked what a “single central database” means to them, eight participants could clearly provide a description. These participants described a “single central database” as a bank of information that all government agencies have access to (n=5) or a giant electronic database (n=3). However, three participants struggled to clearly communicate what a “a single central database” means, failing to demonstrate that they are knowledgeable about this topic. Furthermore, two participants were very unsure about their answer to Q15 and thought a “Don’t know” option would be helpful.

In general, responses to the two questions were consistent (i.e., either “Yes” to both or “No” to both), indicating that when people think a single central database exists, they also think it should exist, or vice versa. One participant said “Yes” to Q15 and “No” to Q16 because they thought the database already exists but should not exist because of data security concerns, while two participants said “No” to Q15 and “Yes” to Q16 because they thought the data base does not currently exist but would be more efficient, more secure, and should exist.

Similar to Q17 (Government agencies already collect data separately about people's jobs, earnings, and participation in government programs but do not always share the data across agencies...) discussed below, it may be unclear to participants whether the examples are an exhaustive list. Two participants were okay with the three pieces of information listed in the question but were not okay with other types of information, like SSN and income. These participants may have been primed by previous discussions to consider other types of data. Another three participants mentioned risks of a single central database in terms of data security.

Recommendations

Overall: Some Issues

Because of the largely consistent answers across both questions, these items may be measuring similar constructs that are not disparate for respondents. We had a small sample size for testing this question due to previous testing that has already been completed. Further input about the results of previous testing should be helpful as we consider how to proceed with these two items.

We may want to consider Q16 for deletion because it is an opinion question asking about a central database, which overlaps with other questions in the survey. If the Census Bureau is interested in respondents’ responses to combining only name, address, and date of birth, then this question does have a distinct construct. However, it is not clear that participants understand this list as exhaustive.

There are no other factual questions in the survey, so we do think it is important to move forward with Q15, but we may want to clarify whether the data items listed are examples or an exhaustive list.

We may want to consider adding a “Don’t know” option for Q15 because it is a factual question and “don’t know” represents a valid response. There were two participants in this sample (n=9) who struggled to choose a response and preferred to have a “Don’t know” option.

We may also consider including a mention of “only” in the question stem. Revising the framing of the question with the additional word of “only” may improve the consistency of respondent comprehension.

Revision Suggestions

English text

Q15

Do you think federal government agencies share a single central database of only the name, address, and date of birth of U.S. residents?

- Yes
- No
- Don’t know

Census feedback

Q15 and Q16 will remain in their original design. Given that the questions are self-explanatory the responses to both questions during cognitive interviews were as anticipated and intended. As such, there is also no need to include the Don’t know option in Q15 since the examples included in the question stem are not exhaustive.

Q17*English text*

Government agencies already collect data separately about people's jobs, earnings, and participation in government programs but do not always share the data across agencies. To what extent are you in favor of or against combining these data sources?

Spanish text

Ya hay agencias del gobierno que obtienen datos por su cuenta sobre el empleo, sueldos y salarios y la participación en programas de gobierno de las personas, pero no siempre comparten los datos con otras agencias. ¿Hasta qué punto está usted a favor o en contra de que se conecten los datos de estas distintas fuentes?

Table 4-17. Responses to Q17

Response	English n=25	Spanish n=15
Strongly in favor of it Sí	5	3
Somewhat in favor of it No	7	2
Neither in favor nor against it	5	3
Somewhat against it	4	3
Strongly against it	4	3
No response	0	1

Findings (n=40)

Almost all participants understood the question as combining information from siloed sources across agencies. However, one participant had significant issues understanding the question. This participant was unable to coherently answer probes and changed his response from “strongly against it” to “strongly in favor of it” during probing.

One additional Spanish-speaking participant also had trouble. They read the question three times and commented they were never fully understood the question. Another participant chose a response but could not elaborate at all during probing.

Some participants (n=5) thought some of the terms were too vague, especially “agencies” and “data.” They wanted more information about which agencies and what types of data would be shared. One participant was unable to choose a response, saying that they did not know what other agencies the question was referring to.

Most participants thought the examples were helpful to understand the question and determine their response. However, five participants thought the list of examples was misleading. Because the text does not include “such as” or “for example,” it is not clear whether the types of data listed are the only information that would be combined or if there are more. One participant explained, “As examples, they are helpful, but I understand in the context of this question, it’s not limited to just these examples, so it could be more... Are these examples all-inclusive or a subset of some options? Maybe if you were to fix this question, it would say, ‘for example.’” Five participants objected specifically to sharing the data mentioned in the examples, especially earnings information. For three of these participants, the examples change their response from “somewhat against it” to “strongly against it” (i.e., if the question included no examples they would answer “somewhat against it”). Another participant was confused by the examples, saying “When they say employment, wages and salaries, I don’t know if they are talking about the employment, wages and salaries of the people who work for the government or who they are talking about.”

One participant thought this question asked the same thing as Q16 (Do you think that federal government agencies **should** share a single central database of the name, address, and date of birth of U.S. residents?). After rereading, participant identified the examples as the difference between Q16 and Q17.

When deciding on their answers, participants brought up some interesting topic-related points. Two participants thought that individuals should provide consent for sharing with other agencies and that it should be their choice about which agencies can access their data. Another three participants thought that combining the data increases the risk of a data breach.

Recommendations

Overall: Some Issues

Although the examples were helpful for participants, the specific examples listed in the question may be unintentionally pushing them to a more negative reaction to combining data. We should discuss whether the examples are providing the appropriate context for participants and if they should be changed, kept, or removed. Participants have an especially strong negative reaction to “earnings”; below we have recommended replacing “earnings” with “taxes” to mitigate concerns.

Some participants were confused whether the three data types listed are all the data that will be shared or just examples. Those who think that more data are shared find the question somewhat misleading. We should consider clarifying that these data types are examples.

This question has overlap with Q18, as discussed in the findings of Q18 below. This question could be a candidate for deletion, especially because it asks a broader question about government agencies in general rather than the focus of Q18 on the Census Bureau.

English text

Government agencies already separately collect data about people, such as about their jobs, taxes, and participation in government programs, but do not always share the data across agencies. To what extent are you in favor of or against combining these data sources?

- Strongly in favor of it
- Somewhat in favor of it
- Neither in favor nor against it
- Somewhat against it
- Strongly against it

Census feedback

Q17 will remain in its original design since taxes as a replacement example are not necessarily better than earnings in the context of this question. The Census Bureau was also not convinced from the available data that identifying the list as examples with the wording “such as” was needed.

Q18*English text*

The Census Bureau is a government agency that is responsible for producing data about the American people and economy. The next few questions ask about the Census Bureau.

Individuals provide information to federal, state, and local agencies when applying for government programs, filing taxes, or completing surveys. The Census Bureau is planning to link this information together to produce statistics.

To what extent are you in favor of or against linking information about individuals?

Spanish text

La Oficina del Censo es una agencia del gobierno encargada de producir información sobre las personas que viven en los Estados Unidos y la economía. Las siguientes preguntas se refieren a la Oficina del Censo.

Las personas proporcionan información a agencias federales, estatales y locales cuando solicitan ayuda de programas del gobierno, declaran impuestos o completan encuestas. La Oficina del Censo planea conectar esta información para producir estadísticas.

¿Hasta qué punto está usted a favor o en contra de conectar la información sobre los individuos?

Table 4-18. Responses to Q18

Response	English n=24	Spanish n=15
Strongly in favor of it Muy a favor	6	5
Somewhat in favor of it Algo a favor	8	4
Neither in favor nor against it Ni a favor ni en contra	5	3
Somewhat against it Algo en contra	3	1
Strongly against it Muy en contra	2	0
No response	0	2

Findings (n=39)

Most participants understand the phrase “linking information,” but eight struggled with the phrase. Three participants were concerned about personally identifiable data being available publicly. One participant specifically struggled to understand what “statistics” meant. One participant focused more on the Census Bureau using information to produce statistics, and it was unclear if they understood the concept of linking. One participant thought this meant data from cognitive interviews would be linked. One participant understood “link this information together” to mean that their individual information would be combined with the information of others in the same community, rather than with another government entity. One Spanish-speaking participant also had a hard time understanding “conectar” (to link) and thought perhaps they meant “colectar” (to collect) and was unclear on what the question was asking. Another participant provided an incoherent response that illustrated they did not understand the question very well.

Two participants thought Q18 was very similar to the previous question Q17 (To what extent are you in favor of or against combining these data sources?).

Participants who were in favor of linking can more often think of clear benefits to linking the data, such as greater efficiency or more accurate statistics (n=5).

Four participants wanted more information to form a confident opinion. Three of these participants answered “neither,” indicating that this category serves as a “don’t know” response for some participants. Two participants were unclear on the purpose of the Census Bureau linking all the information. One participant commented, “If Census wants to know how many people are in your house, that’s fine but why do they need all that other information?” This participant felt especially unclear on the benefits of linking the data together.

Three participants changed their responses after discussion the question further, all in a positive direction (i.e., from “neither” to “somewhat in favor”). These participants reread the question at least once. Further discussion helped them think through the pros and cons of linking information and influenced them to respond more positively than their initial reaction.

Recommendations

Overall: Some Issues

This question contains a lot of information for participants to absorb, and it is difficult for some of them to understand. The comprehension issue is reflected when three participants changed their answers during probing, the number of people selecting “neither” as a substitute for “don’t know,” and the confusion over what “linking information” means.

When participants are clear on the benefits of linking information, they seem to be more in favor of it. Because the benefits are more clearly laid out in Q20 and there is also some overlap between Q17 and Q18, this question may be a candidate for deletion.

If there is an analytic need to keep a question as a benchmark to compare with Q20 (frames experiment), we recommend keeping Q18 over Q17 because Q18 is more specifically related to the target of interest (i.e., the Census Bureau).

Census feedback

Similar to Q17's decision, Q18 will remain in its original form.

Q19*English text*

The Census Bureau is planning to use information about individuals, available from private companies, such as your contact information or age. This information would only be used to produce statistics.

To what extent are you in favor of or against the Census Bureau obtaining your information from private companies?

Spanish text

La Oficina del Censo está planeando usar información sobre los individuos, como sus datos de contacto o su edad, que puede obtener de compañías privadas. Esa información sólo se usaría para generar estadísticas.

¿Hasta qué punto está usted a favor o en contra de que la Oficina del Censo obtenga su información de compañías privadas?

Table 4-19. Responses to Q19

Response	English n=23	Spanish n=15
Strongly in favor of it Muy a favor	3	3
Somewhat in favor of it Algo a favor	2	3
Neither in favor nor against it Ni a favor ni en contra	9	2
Somewhat against it Algo en contra	4	3
Strongly against it Muy en contra	5	3
No response	0	1

Findings (n=38)

When presented with this question, two Spanish-speaking participants thought that the question was saying that the Census Bureau would share data with private companies, which worried the participants.

Some participants want more information to inform their opinion. Six participants felt the purpose and benefits of this data sharing between private companies and the Census Bureau was unclear. Three of these six participants wanted to know more about the purpose

of gathering information from private companies, with two of these participants selecting “Neither in favor nor against it.” The other three participants who were unclear on the purpose and benefits wanted clarity on what the statistics would be used for, with two of these participants selecting “Neither in favor nor against it.” Of the six participants who were unclear about the purpose and benefits, two did not select “Neither for nor against it.” These two participants who did not answer “Neither for nor against it” seemed to default to their overall feelings about the topic when they did not have enough information in the question to provide a nuanced answer. One of these participants answered, “strongly against,” citing his concerns about sharing information more broadly, whereas the other answered “strongly in favor,” citing her positive feelings about and trust in the Census Bureau more generally.

Three participants wanted to know whether individuals will consent to the information being shared when they interact with the companies. These participants are concerned about being informed about their data being shared with the Census Bureau. Two participants wanted to know which companies their data would be collected from. Three other participants spontaneously mentioned that they were thinking about social media companies. A few participants (n=2) worried about the accuracy of information obtained from private companies.

Most participants understood the phrase “only be used to produce statistics,” but four struggled with it. Two of these participants were unclear what this phrase meant and two of these participants thought that the phrase was not clearly communicating that data would be analyzed in aggregate rather than individual responses. One additional participant pointed out that the example of contact information did not make sense because it was unclear how contact information could be used to produce statistics.

Other findings included one participant who felt it was not clear what was meant by “individuals” in the question and was unsure how to answer. Three participants answered “neither” when they did not know enough about the topic to have an opinion. Two participants believe that the Census Bureau already has data on age and contact information. They were confused about why the Census Bureau would need to collect this information from private companies. Two participants spontaneously thought of information from their credit being shared with the Census Bureau, even though this is not a listed example.

Recommendations

Overall: Some Issues

Participants are unclear on the reasons why the Census Bureau wants to gather information from private companies, leading many participants to answer “neither.” As expected, not all participants understand the term “statistics.” However, several participants specifically

pointed out that “only be used to produce statistics” did not communicate that the information would be aggregated. Furthermore, the example of contact information made participants question whether their information would be identifiable. Based on this, we should consider changing the example “contact information” to something less sensitive but more straightforward to improve clarity. We recommend using “where you live” in the question stem, which can be aggregated to be used as statistics.

English text

The Census Bureau is planning to use information about individuals, available from private companies, such as your age or where you live. This information would only be used to produce statistics.

To what extent are you in favor of or against the Census Bureau obtaining your information from private companies?

- Strongly in favor of it
- Somewhat in favor of it
- Neither in favor nor against it
- Somewhat against it
- Strongly against it

Census feedback

Q19 will remain in its original design. Contact info and age are big pieces of data that we get from private companies. When we present data from this question, we will note that the neutral option could be a default for people who were not sure about context.

Q20

English text

The Census Bureau plans to build a new database that combines information from other government agencies, government surveys you may have answered in the past, and private companies. This database will [FRAME]. The database will only be used to produce statistics. To what extent are you in favor of or against the Census Bureau building this database?

Spanish text

La Oficina del Censo planea crear una nueva base de datos que conecte información de otras agencias de gobierno, encuestas de gobierno que usted haya contestado antes, y de compañías privadas. Esta base de datos [FRAME]. La base de datos se usará únicamente para generar estadísticas. ¿Hasta qué punto está usted a favor o en contra de que la Oficina del Censo cree esta base de datos?

Table 4-20. Responses to Q20

First Frame	Second Frame	English n=23	Spanish n=15
FRAME 1: This database will mean that you are asked to fill out government surveys less often because your information is already available. FRAME 1: Esta base de datos hará que le pidan a usted que conteste encuestas de gobierno con menos frecuencia porque su información ya estaría disponible.	FRAME 2: This database will help government agencies make better use of taxpayer money. FRAME 2: ayudará a las agencias de gobierno a hacer un mejor uso del dinero que pagan los contribuyentes	6	2
FRAME 2: This database will help government agencies make better use of taxpayer money. FRAME 2: Esta base de datos ayudará a las agencias de gobierno a hacer un mejor uso del dinero que pagan los contribuyentes.	FRAME 3: This database will help your local government deliver services and benefits more efficiently. FRAME 3: ayudará a su gobierno local a ofrecer servicios y beneficios de manera más eficiente	2	3
FRAME 3: This database will help your local government deliver services and benefits more efficiently. FRAME 3: Esta base de datos ayudará a su gobierno local a ofrecer servicios y beneficios de manera más eficiente.	FRAME 4: This database will mean that information and statistics about the country are more accurate. FRAME 4: hará que la información y las estadísticas del país sean más precisas	5	4

First Frame	Second Frame	English n=23	Spanish n=15
FRAME 4: This database will mean that information and statistics about the country are more accurate. FRAME 4: Esta base de datos hará que la información y las estadísticas del país sean más precisas.	FRAME 5: This database will help complete survey responses when information is missing. FRAME 5: ayudará a completar respuestas de la encuesta cuando falta información	6	3
FRAME 5: This database will help complete survey responses when information is missing. FRAME 5: Esta base de datos ayudará a completar respuestas de la encuesta cuando falta información.	FRAME 1: This database will mean that you are asked to fill out government surveys less often because your information is already available. FRAME 1: hará que le pidan a usted que conteste encuestas de gobierno con menos frecuencia porque su información ya estaría disponible	4	3

Table 4-21. Comprehension of the Frames by Language

Frame	Total exposure		Consistent understanding		Inconsistent understanding	
	English	Spanish	English	Spanish	English	Spanish
Frame 1	10	4	9	3	1	1
Frame 2	8	5	8	5	0	0
Frame 3	7	7	5	7	2	0
Frame 4	11	7	9	5	2	2
Frame 5	10	6	8	3	2	3
Total	46	29	39	23	7	6

Note: one participant (SP13) saw the same frame twice in error. Probes on understanding were skipped in an additional interview (SP3)

Table 4-22. Responses to Q20 by Exposure Sequence

All responses	First exposure (n=23)		Second exposure (n=22)*	
	English	Spanish	English	Spanish
Strongly in favor of it Muy a favor	4	7	5	7
Somewhat in favor of it Algo a favor	10	5	11	5
Neither in favor nor against it Ni a favor ni en contra	2	0	0	0

All responses	First exposure (n=23)		Second exposure (n=22)*	
	English	Spanish	English	Spanish
Somewhat against it Algo en contra	1	1	2	1
Strongly against it Muy en contra	5	2	4	2

*Note: one participant (P54) did not specify what their response would be to the second frame.

Table 4-23. Responses to Q20 by Frames

Responses for each frame across both exposures	Frame 1		Frame 2		Frame 3		Frame 4		Frame 5	
	English	Spanish	English	Spanish	English	Spanish	English	Spanish	English	Spanish
Strongly in favor of it Muy a favor	2	3	2	3	3	2	2	2	1	5
Somewhat in favor of it Algo a favor	5	0	3	1	3	5	6	3	5	0
Neither in favor nor against it Ni a favor ni en contra	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	0	1	0
Somewhat against it Algo en contra	1	0	1	1	0	0	0	0	1	0
Strongly against it Muy en contra	2	1	2	0	1	1	1	1	2	1

Findings (n=38)

Most participants consistently understood all five frames as they were written and presented in the question. Only one participant seemed to have trouble understanding the question and the two frames (Frames 1 and 5) he reviewed during the interview. At least another seven participants were confused about one of the frames during the interview, but they seemed to understand the question and were able to produce an answer without problem.

Generally, these participants expressed difficulty in thinking of concrete benefits based on these frames to reflect their understanding of the frames. For example, when being asked to describe Frame 3, one participant commented, "I really don't know – maybe police or ambulance response time."

Similarly, other participants brought up irrelevant information they learned from the previous questions (e.g., hacking, data availability, or government service delivery) as their comment on the frame they were reviewing. Such a misconnection can explain the misunderstanding of two participants: One participant thought Frame 1 meant that “the database can fill in the missing information that is being collected” while another participant thought the benefit of Frame 4 as “distribution of money around the country, where are people poor and need more help.”

Some participants found some of the statements vague and were unable to see them as directly relatable benefits to them individually. This issue is more apparent for Frames 1 and 5. For example, one participant said in reaction to Frame 5 that “People may be skipping for a reason, and you’re taking that right away from them to not answer.” This sentiment was echoed by at least one other participant. Two other participants made a similar comment about Frame 1, with one participant confused about the statement, questioning the reason of conducting surveys if the Census Bureau wants to let people answer surveys less often with this database. Even as another participant understood the meaning of Frame 1, he still expressed a mild concern of lacking the direct personal connection to the benefit: “I’ll have to answer less questions because the Census knows more about me already. Although they only ask questions once a decade so not sure how much less questions they could ask.” One participant indicated some concerns about Frame 3 even though they could better relate to the benefits suggested in Frame 3 than those in Frame 2: “[Frame 3] means it’s going to target its services toward the community in a more efficient, relevant way, I can see a benefit to that. So, it’s an improvement on the previous question [Frame 2]. But I still don’t know—what types of services? What types of benefits? If you’re not someone who relies on government services, then it’s not going to mean anything.” Similarly, another participant felt that Frame 2 was too broad without examples and was more leading than Frame 1.

When participants discussed the two different frames they reviewed, they preferred the frame that had clearer benefits and was more concrete and relatable. A few participants thought Frame 2 is a better statement with a clear definition about the benefits of the database than Frame 1 (n=2). For example, a participant indicated that “[Frame 2] is better - the other [Frame 1] refers to surveys and this one is more pointed and focused on fiscal responsibility.” Additionally, “[Frame 2] gives a clear understanding of the benefit I’d get out of this arrangement as a taxpayer. Makes the advantage much clearer [than Frame 1].”

Another two participants considered Frame 3 a better statement than Frame 2 and Frame 4, respectively. For example, one participant explained, “I prefer the first one [Frame 3]. Efficiency is the larger word that encompasses accuracy. If one is efficient, then it is because you have access to accurate data. [You] could be accurate but not very efficient.” Another participant also found Frame 3 easier to understand than Frame 2. An additional participant who saw Frames 2 and 3 mentioned that Frame 2, with its reference to the use of taxpayer money, made her think about her local government while Frame 3, with its

reference to services and benefits being delivered efficiently, made her think about the country as a whole. Another participant thought that Frame 5 was clearer than Frame 4, saying that people may not understand what is meant by “accurate” and that missing information is much clearer. Another participant thought that Frame 4 was clearer than Frame 3.

Overall, most participants did not change their initial response to Q20 while they were reviewing and discussing the second frame during the interview. Only six participants changed their responses between frames; the frame sentence is likely not playing a big part in the response process. See the table below for a summary of changes in responses. Two participants changed their answers because they considered the second frame they were presented as more concrete than the first frame; and they were able to understand and relate to the benefits suggested in the second frame. One participant had this reaction when first presented with Frame 5 and then Frame 1. Similarly, this participant did not fully understand Frame 5 and how this would benefit them individually. Another participant changed their response because the accuracy described in Frame 4 was more compelling than the efficiency described in Frame 3. Another changed their answer because they were worried that in Frame 5 the methods to fill in missing survey responses would lead to less accurate statistics. This participant also never provides income data (including outside of the cognitive interview), and this may have also contributed to their more negative rating of Frame 5. Another participant changed their answer to “strongly in favor” for Frame 5, saying they thought the missing information being filled in would be used to improve their neighborhood.

Table 4-24. Participants Who Changed Responses to Q20 between Frames

Participants Who Changed Responses between Frames (n=6)				
ID	First Frame	First Answer	Second Frame	Second Answer
P33	Frame 3	Somewhat in favor	Frame 4	Strongly in favor
P84	Frame 4	Neither	Frame 5	Somewhat in favor
P69	Frame 4	Somewhat in favor	Frame 5	Somewhat against
SP5	Frame 4	Somewhat in favor	Frame 5	Strongly in favor
P50	Frame 5	Neither	Frame 1	Strongly in favor
P25	Frame 5	Strongly against	Frame 1	Somewhat in favor

While elaborating on their answers to the question, several participants commented on the roles of private companies in the context of the question (n=9). However, such a comment is not exclusively reserved to the reaction to the frames by these participants. These participants feel negatively about data sharing between the government and private

companies and react this way across questions that mention private companies. Only one participant speculated that “maybe private companies have newer information” while discussing what Frame 5 meant for their answer to the question. The other eight participants expressed their discontent regarding the Census Bureau collecting information from private companies for the database. For example, one participant commented, “I think it’s better that the government shares information among themselves, but I’m a little uncomfortable with private companies being a part of it.” One participant was confused by the mention of “compañías privadas” (private companies) in the question and asked, “Like companies hired by the government to do direct surveys or what?”

Two participants who saw frames that referenced missing information commented they thought that missing information was often left off for a reason, and the government should go back to people and ask for it rather than ask private companies for it.

Recommendations

Overall: Some Issues

Although most participants understood and interpreted all five frames in the context of the question consistently and report their opinion with little difficulty, the findings indicated some concerns about the vagueness of all five frames. These concerns are consistent with the expert review report, as our experts suspected that the frames may not clearly resonate with respondents as benefits.

Although Frame 1 seems to be a concrete and direct benefit for individuals in the expert review, some participants either did not see the statement as a concrete and relatable benefit or considered the benefits of other frames (such as Frame 2) as more concrete or relatable. It is possible that “filling out surveys less often” is not as relatable as expected, when the average person only has to fill out the Census every 10 years. The mention of information availability may also invoke unrelated skepticism about privacy and distract survey respondents further from discerning their opinion about the benefits of the database. Similarly, Frame 5 elicits the same concerns as Frame 1 but to a lesser extent. In addition, some participants expressed their discontent of losing the discretion of providing a nonresponse for privacy reasons. Frames 2, 3 and 4 are seen as more relatable, concrete benefits of the database by some participants compared with Frames 1 and 5. Although these frames worked as intended during the cognitive interview, a few participants still expressed their desire of examples because they were not very confident about their understanding of these frames.

If the goal of the frame experiment is to understand whether the general population may express a different opinion about the database based on the different benefits, then Frame 1 may be a potential candidate for removal from the experiment, given that it did not work

as well as expected with the issues revealed during the cognitive interview. Additionally, Frame 5 might be considered for removal for the same concerns.

If it is important to keep Frame 1, then we may want to consider removing the phrase “because your information is already available” because it may trigger privacy concerns rather than being understood as a benefit.

Census feedback

Q20 will move forward with the existing design for the national data collection with a minor tweak for Frame 1. The wording for Frame 1 will be updated to “This database will mean that you are asked to fill out government surveys less often because your information is already available from other agencies.”

Q21*English text*

Individuals provide information about themselves to the federal government for a variety of reasons - including when they apply for passports, participate in programs such as Medicare, or submit their tax forms. Being able to use information you provide for additional purposes can improve the delivery of government benefits and services and save taxpayer money.

To what extent are you in favor of or against the information you provided for one purpose being used by the government in additional ways?

Spanish text

Los individuos proporcionan información sobre sí mismos al gobierno federal por diversas razones, como cuando solicitan pasaportes, participan en programas como Medicare o presentan su declaración de impuestos. Poder usar la información que usted proporciona para otros propósitos puede mejorar la manera en que el gobierno reparte beneficios y servicios y puede ahorrar el dinero de los contribuyentes.

¿Hasta qué punto está a favor o en contra de que la información que usted proporcionó para un cierto propósito sea usada por el gobierno para propósitos diferentes?

Table 4-25. Responses to Q21

Response	English n=23	Spanish n=15
Strongly in favor of it Muy a favor	3	3
Somewhat in favor of it Algo a favor	9	4
Neither in favor nor against it Ni a favor ni en contra	4	0
Somewhat against it Algo en contra	1	1
Strongly against it Muy en contra	3	2

Findings (n=30)

The participants consistently understood this question as asking whether they were in favor or against the government sharing information they gave in one instance for other

purposes. However, one participant had a hard time understanding the question and was only able to gain a general understanding after reading the question three times.

When asked about what additional ways information could be used, many participants reiterated the examples in the question (n=6). Others provided new examples, such as tracking/reporting crimes, medical benefits, DMV applications, and job opportunities (n=7). A few mentioned the benefits described in the question (i.e., "improve the delivery of government benefits and services and save taxpayer money") as the additional ways their data would be used (n=2). One participant mentioned better statistics as an additional way for the data to be used, which was an example from the previous question. Some participants struggled to think of additional ways and thought the term was too vague (n=2). One participant said that an example of an additional purpose could be the government in Texas could know who in the Uvalde area has children and survey them about what they want to do for school security going forward. Two participants could not come up with any other purpose the government could use the information for when asked.

The main takeaway reported below from responses to Q22 is that participants want to know more about the additional ways, even those who respond in favor. Those who concretely understand the benefits listed in the question and agree that they are benefits tend to answer more positively (n=7). In contrast, participants who doubt the benefits respond more negatively (n=3). Some participants specifically thought about community benefits rather than individual benefits, such as funding for community programs (n=3).

Other findings included two participants that thought this question was very similar to Q20. Three participants thought the question is somewhat leading and trying to make respondents feel more positively about the sharing of data that are already collected. While four participants brought up the question of whether someone would be able to explicitly consent to additional uses of their data at the point of providing the information.

Recommendations

Overall: Some Issues

Though not explicitly asked, two participants volunteered that this question is very similar to previous questions about sharing data, indicating that this question overlaps with other items. The context provided in the question has a high cognitive burden to read and comprehend. Additionally, participants are reacting to the benefits listed in the question to form their responses instead of the idea of sharing information between agencies. Participants also struggled to think of additional ways their information would be used outside of the examples and benefits listed in the question, relying instead only on the information provided in the question text.

Due to these reasons, we recommend this question as a candidate for deletion, especially considering the length of the text, which poses higher burden than other similar questions, and the potential for measurement error.

Census feedback

Q21 will remain in the questionnaire as the finding does not suggest a respondent burden that exceeds the expectation.

Q22

English text

You said you were [FILL RESPONSE TO Q21, e.g., “strongly in favor of”] your data being used for new purposes after it has been collected. Please tell us more about your answer.

Spanish text

Usted dijo que estaba [FILL RESPONSE TO Q21, e.g., “muy a favor”] de que sus datos se usen para otros propósitos después de que se hayan obtenido. Por favor cuénteme un poco más sobre su respuesta.

[Open-ended]

Findings (n=25)

When reflecting further on their answers to Q21, even participants who answered favorably wanted to know more information about the “new purposes” (n=7). In their open-ended responses, three participants reiterated that they would prefer to consent for new purposes. Several participants listed benefits, such as expanded social programs, to explain why they selected their answer (n=7). One participant said they worried about the information being obtained without their consent and the risk of identity theft. One participant said that Q21 felt to them like they were being scammed, and that their information was being collected in a deceitful way. Another two participants included information that did not seem to add explanation to their responses to Q21. One participant mentioned that she likes that the disability website gives updates based on previous data, and another said they were thinking about global warming. One participant could not think of any information to add, while two participants mentioned concern about companies accessing their data.

Recommendations

Overall: Some Issues

If we keep Q21, then it may be better to present the full question text from Q21 when asking this open-ended follow up. Because all responses will lead to this question, it should be okay to present it on the same screen (i.e., there are no skip pattern concerns). This placement could help reduce extraneous answers and make sure participants are thinking directly about Q21.

With this new placement, we may consider altering this question to be more straight forward, for example only asking: “Please tell us more about how you decided on your answer.” This new placement removes the need for reiterating the question context because the questions will appear on the same screen. Alternatively, Q22 could be used as a follow up to another question if we rephrase the first sentence.

Census feedback

Q22 will be programmed as an in-screen pop up on the same web page, and the question stem will be simplified as suggested previously.

Consistent with the question presentation during the cognitive interviews, Questions 23, 24, and 25 were analyzed together.

English text

To what extent are you in favor of or against the Census Bureau getting the following types of information from other government agencies?

Spanish text

¿Hasta qué punto está usted a favor o en contra de que la Oficina del Censo obtenga los siguientes tipos de información de otras agencias de gobierno?

Q23

English text

Your contact information, such as phone numbers and email addresses

Spanish text

Su información de contacto, como sus números de teléfono y sus direcciones de correo electrónico

Table 4-26. Responses to Q23

Response	English n=7	Spanish n=2
Strongly in favor of it Muy a favor	1	0
Somewhat in favor of it Algo a favor	1	2
Neither in favor nor against it Ni a favor ni en contra	2	0
Somewhat against it Algo en contra	1	0
Strongly against it Muy en contra	2	0

Q24

English text

Whether your address was occupied or vacant on a particular date

Spanish text

Si su dirección estaba ocupada o desocupada en una fecha en particular

Table 4-27. Responses to Q24

Response	English n=7	Spanish n=2
Strongly in favor of it Muy a favor	1	0
Somewhat in favor of it Algo a favor	0	1
Neither in favor nor against it Ni a favor ni en contra	2	1
Somewhat against it Algo en contra	2	0
Strongly against it Muy en contra	2	0

Q25*English text*

Your demographic information, such as your age, race, or marital status

Spanish text

Su información demográfica, como edad, raza o estado civil

Table 4-28. Responses to Q25

Response	English n=7	Spanish n=2
Strongly in favor of it Muy a favor	1	1
Somewhat in favor of it Algo a favor	2	1
Neither in favor nor against it Ni a favor ni en contra	3	0
Somewhat against it Algo en contra	0	0
Strongly against it Muy en contra	1	0

Findings (n=9)

When we asked participants what they thought “vacant” meant to them (Q24), most participants did not have difficulty understanding what this meant. Some participants

interpreted “vacant” to mean that no one lived at the residence on that date or the residence was unoccupied (n=6). However, two participants had some difficulties with the term “vacant.” One participant was not sure what the term “vacant” meant and another participant interpreted “vacant” as either the residence was unoccupied on that date or that the resident was not there on that date.

Other findings included one participant commenting that they were not sure why the Census Bureau would need someone’s phone number and email address but understanding why they would want to collect demographic information. Another participant struggled to understand Q24 until they re-read the question stem.

Recommendations

Overall: Few Issues

From the small sample that tested this question, there were two participants who struggled with the term “vacant.” However, the Census Bureau has tested “vacant” before with no issues (as reported in the Expert Review Report). When considering programming of the final survey, it will be important for the question stem to remain on screen as respondents evaluate all the items.

Census feedback

None.

Consistent with the question presentation during the cognitive interviews, Questions 26, 27, and 28 were analyzed together.

English text

To what extent are you in favor of or against the Census Bureau getting the following types of information from other government agencies?

Spanish text

¿Hasta qué punto está usted a favor o en contra de que la Oficina del Censo obtenga los siguientes tipos de información de otras agencias de gobierno?

Q26

English text

Whether you own or rent the home where you live

Spanish text

Si usted es dueño(a) o alquila la vivienda en la que vive

Table 4-29. Responses to Q26

Response	English n=18	Spanish n=10
Strongly in favor of it Muy a favor	8	5
Somewhat in favor of it Algo a favor	3	2
Neither in favor nor against it Ni a favor ni en contra	2	3
Somewhat against it Algo en contra	1	0
Strongly against it Muy en contra	4	0

Q27

English text

Your income you reported on your tax forms

Spanish text

El ingreso que reportó en su declaración de impuestos

Table 4-30. Responses to Q27

Response	English n=18	Spanish n=9
Strongly in favor of it Muy a favor	5	3
Somewhat in favor of it Algo a favor	5	4
Neither in favor nor against it Ni a favor ni en contra	1	1
Somewhat against it Algo en contra	2	0
Strongly against it Muy en contra	5	1

Q28*English text*

The number of people in your household

Spanish text

El número de personas en su hogar

Table 4-31. Responses to Q28

Response	English n=18	Spanish n=9
Strongly in favor of it Muy a favor	9	4
Somewhat in favor of it Algo a favor	2	2
Neither in favor nor against it Ni a favor ni en contra	4	2
Somewhat against it Algo en contra	0	0
Strongly against it Muy en contra	3	1

Findings (n=28)

Some participants questioned whether the Census Bureau already had access to these pieces of information about them. Three participants thought that the Census Bureau

already collected the number of people in their household (Q28). Two of these participants responded to the survey question that they would be in favor of the Census Bureau getting access to this information. Similar to trends reported on previous questions, one participant said “neither in favor nor against it” as a way to represent their lack of knowledge about the topic (i.e., the “neither” option serves as a “don’t know”). This participant answered “neither” on both Q26 and Q28. Two participants were only comfortable with sharing their income (Q27) in certain situations. One participant said they were more comfortable sharing a range rather than a specific number, while another participant said they want to be able to consent to sharing income information and was not comfortable with the Census Bureau having access to this information without explicitly asking. Similarly, another participant said they did not want the government to know how much money they make. Another participant commented that it would be nice to understand the purpose of why they want to know if someone is a homeowner or a renter.

Recommendations

Overall: Few Issues

Answers to these questions may be influenced by participants’ belief that the Census Bureau already has access to this information. No revisions recommended, but this thematic finding may inform whether the question meets the analytic goals.

Census feedback

None.

Consistent with the question presentation during the cognitive interviews, Questions 29, 30, 31, and 32 were analyzed together.

English text

To what extent are you in favor of or against the Census Bureau getting your information from the following sources?

Spanish text

¿Hasta qué punto está usted a favor o en contra de que la Oficina del Censo obtenga su información de las siguientes fuentes?

Q29

English text

The Social Security Administration (SSA)

Spanish text

La Administración del Seguro Social (*Social Security*)

Table 4-32. Responses to Q29

Response	English n=18	Spanish n=8
Strongly in favor of it Muy a favor	5	3
Somewhat in favor of it Algo a favor	3	1
Neither in favor nor against it Ni a favor ni en contra	4	2
Somewhat against it Algo en contra	1	1
Strongly against it Muy en contra	5	1

Q30

English text

The Internal Revenue Service (IRS)

Spanish text

La agencia que recauda impuestos (Servicio de Impuestos Internos o IRS por sus siglas en inglés)

Table 4-33. Responses to Q30

Response	English n=18	Spanish n=8
Strongly in favor of it Muy a favor	6	3
Somewhat in favor of it Algo a favor	2	2
Neither in favor nor against it Ni a favor ni en contra	3	2
Somewhat against it Algo en contra	2	0
Strongly against it Muy en contra	5	1

Q31*English text*[Your state department of motor vehicles](#)*Spanish text*[El departamento de registro de vehículos de su estado](#)**Table 4-34. Responses to Q31**

Response	English n=18	Spanish n=8
Strongly in favor of it Muy a favor	7	3
Somewhat in favor of it Algo a favor	2	1
Neither in favor nor against it Ni a favor ni en contra	3	3
Somewhat against it Algo en contra	2	0
Strongly against it Muy en contra	4	1

Q32*English text*

A credit reporting company, like Experian or Equifax

Spanish text

Una compañía de informes de crédito, como Experian o Equifax

Table 4-35. Responses to Q32

Response	English n=18	Spanish n=9
Strongly in favor of it Muy a favor	3	0
Somewhat in favor of it Algo a favor	2	2
Neither in favor nor against it Ni a favor ni en contra	3	3
Somewhat against it Algo en contra	1	1
Strongly against it Muy en contra	9	1
Unable to answer	0	1

Findings (n=26)

Some participants questioned what data these different sources have, and what the Census Bureau would be able to or want to access from each (n=4). For two of these participants, this confusion resulted in them answering “neither in favor nor against” for those questions while for two other participants, this confusion resulted in them saying they were against the Census Bureau accessing information from these sources.

When asked why someone would be in favor of the Census Bureau collecting information from these sources, participants said it would produce statistics that are more complete or accurate (n=4) and it would be more efficient and save taxpayer money (n=2). Several participants were not sure why someone would be in favor of this (n=6). One participant simply said it would be because a person is interested in the Census Bureau having access to people’s personal information, while another participant said that people who were not afraid of being investigated would be in favor of this information being collected.

Additional findings included one participant that thought Q29 (SSA) implied that this is how the Census Bureau would find out the citizenship status of individuals. One participant

commented that other questions in this survey asked similar things as these questions, but these were more specific. One participant commented that they were not familiar with the examples of credit reporting companies and so were unsure of how to answer. When asked how they would answer if the question just asked about “a credit reporting company”, the participant was able to answer.

Recommendations

Overall: Few Issues

Participant lack of knowledge about the data each of these sources has may influence responses. No revisions recommended, but this thematic finding may inform whether the question meets the analytic goals.

Census feedback

None.

Q33

Consistent with the question presentation during the cognitive interviews, Questions 33, 34, and 35 were analyzed together.

English text

The population count, the crime rate, and the unemployment rate are examples of statistics produced by the federal government. Have you ever used federal statistics for study or work?

Spanish text

El conteo de la población, el índice de criminalidad y el índice de desempleo son ejemplos de las estadísticas producidas por el gobierno federal. ¿Alguna vez ha usado estadísticas federales para los estudios o el trabajo?

Table 4-36. Responses to Q33

Response	English n=6	Spanish n=1
Yes, I have used federal statistics for study or work Sí, he usado estadísticas federales en mis estudios o en mi trabajo	3	0
No, I have not used federal statistics for study or work No, no he usado estadísticas federales ni en mis estudios ni en mi trabajo	3	1

Q34

English text

Personally, how much trust do you have in federal statistics in the United States? Would you say that you tend to trust federal statistics or you tend not to trust them?

Spanish text

Personalmente, ¿cuánta confianza tiene usted en las estadísticas federales en los Estados Unidos? ¿Diría que tiende a confiar en las estadísticas federales o que tiende a no confiar en ellas?

Table 4-37. Responses to Q34

Response	English n=6	Spanish n=1
Tend to trust federal statistics Tiendo a confiar en las estadísticas federales	4	0
Tend not to trust federal statistics Tiendo a no confiar en las estadísticas federales	2	1

Q35*English text*

To what extent do you agree or disagree with the following statement?

Policy makers need federal statistics to make good decisions about things like federal funding.

Spanish text

¿Hasta qué punto está de acuerdo o en desacuerdo con la siguiente afirmación?

Los legisladores necesitan las estadísticas federales para tomar buenas decisiones acerca de cosas como los fondos federales.

Table 4-38. Responses to Q35

Response	English n=6	Spanish n=1
Strongly agree Muy de acuerdo	5	0
Somewhat agree Algo de acuerdo	0	1
Neither agree nor disagree Ni de acuerdo ni en desacuerdo	0	0
Somewhat disagree Algo en desacuerdo	0	0
Strongly disagree Muy en desacuerdo	1	0

Findings (n=7)

The term “federal statistics” was well understood among participants (n=3) who have used federal data in the past (i.e., answered “yes” to Q33). However, other participants relied on

the examples in the question to define the phrase, and it was unclear whether they had a confident understanding of the term (n=3).

One participant wondered about the meaning of “trust” in Q34, showing that the question may not be consistently understood, asking, “Trust as in what they will do with [the statistics] or whether they are accurate?”

When asked about “policy makers,” participants provided the following examples: people in government (e.g., congress, senators, cabinet/committee leaders, legislators, and politicians); decision makers at large on topics like Medicare/Medicaid or education; and other professionals (e.g., social workers, lawyers, advocates).

Though a small sample size, there are interesting patterns of response across the three questions. All participants who have used federal statistics (n=3) indicated that they trust the statistics and strongly agree that federal statistics are needed for decision making. One participant who has not used federal statistics reported that they tend to trust the statistics, while the other two participants who have not used federal statistics tend not to trust the statistics.

Recommendations

Overall: Some Issues

“Federal statistics” may not be a well-understood term, but for Q33, does not impact the response process for people who are familiar with and have used federal statistics for work or school. The lack of understanding is a greater concern for Q34 and Q35. We may want to consider implementing a skip pattern based on the analytic needs for this set of questions. We could ask Q34 and Q35 only of those who answer “yes” to Q33, or only to those who answer “no.” This approach could help reduce respondent burden. Alternatively, we may want to cut Q34 and Q35 because responses to these questions seem to relate directly to whether participants have used federal statistics in the past (Q33). This limited testing shows that participants think of a wide variety of people when they consider “policy makers,” but due to previous testing we are not concerned about this finding.

Census feedback

Q34 and Q35 will remain as they are given that the estimated response time of the whole instrument by Ipsos’ testing did not exceed the proposed burden.

Q36

Consistent with the question presentation during the cognitive interviews, Questions 36 and 37 were analyzed together.

English text

How concerned are you about information you give to the Census Bureau being stolen through hacking or a data breach?

Spanish text

¿Qué tan preocupado(a) está de que la información que usted le da a la Oficina del Censo, la roben hackers (piratas informáticos) o que haya una falla en la seguridad de datos personales?

Table 4-39. Responses to Q36

Response	English n=6	Spanish n=1
Extremely concerned Extremadamente preocupado(a)	2	0
Moderately concerned Moderadamente preocupado(a)	1	1
A little concerned Poco preocupado(a)	3	0
Not at all concerned Para nada preocupado(a)	0	0

*Note: Because of lack of time in the initial interviews and because these questions were removed from later interviews, only one Spanish speaking participant was asked these questions, and that person was not asked any probes.

Q37*English text*

How likely do you think it is that information you give the Census Bureau will be stolen through hacking or a data breach?

Spanish text

¿Qué tan probable cree que sea que la información que usted le da a la Oficina del Censo, la roben hackers (piratas informáticos) o que haya una falla en la seguridad de datos personales?

Table 4-40. Responses to Q37

Response	English n=6	Spanish n=1
Not at all likely Nada probable	1	0
A little bit likely Un poco probable	3	1
Moderately likely Moderadamente probable	2	0
Very likely Muy probable	0	0

*Note: Because of lack of time in the initial interviews and because these questions were removed from later interviews, only one Spanish speaking participant was asked these questions, and that person was not asked any probes.

Findings (n=7)

Overall, participants did not have difficulties in understanding “data breach” or “hacking.” Three participants saw overlap in “data breach” and “hacking.” Participants generally defined a “data breach” as someone getting access to data they were not supposed to have access to (n=4). One participant was not sure how to define a “data breach.” While similar to a “data breach,” participants generally defined “hacking” as the process of a data breach (n=3), with one participant specifying that a data breach could be an accident, but hacking has malicious intent.

Three participants mentioned examples of data breaches, including Russian or Chinese attacks on data; health insurance data breaches; and data breaches of credit card information or addresses.

Unlike Q5 (discussed previously) and Q38 (discussed below), participants did not discuss any issues with the response options used in Q36.

Recommendations

Overall: Few Issues

No revisions recommended.

Census feedback

See Q05 for discussion of changes implemented to the scale across the instrument, including Q36. The scale used for Q37 will also be updated to use the wording “Somewhat likely” instead of “Moderately likely” to improve clarity and reduce potential comprehension issues.

Q38*English text**In general, how concerned are you about your personal privacy?**Spanish text**En general, ¿qué tan preocupado(a) diría usted que está sobre su privacidad personal?***Table 4-41. Responses to Q38**

Response	English n=17	Spanish n=15
Extremely concerned Extremadamente preocupado(a)	4	1
Moderately concerned Moderadamente preocupado(a)	8	0
A little concerned Poco preocupado(a)	3	2
Not at all concerned Para nada preocupado(a)	2	3

Findings (n=32)

Overall, participants understood the question consistently and thought concern about personal privacy meant being worried about their information or taking action to protect their privacy. A few participants specifically thought about financial information when considering “personal privacy” (n=2). However, one participant deviated on her understanding of the term “personal privacy.” She thought “personal privacy” meant privacy in terms of the physical space around her. Another participant said it was about feeling that your personal information would be used to harm you, explaining, “Whether I think that they are going to do something to me, that just because the entities have all that kind of information, they are going to arrest me, follow me, do something to me.”

When asked the difference between “Moderately concerned” and “A little concerned,” most participants thought there was a clear difference between these two response options. Some participants described this as the difference between wanting to/already having taken action to protect their personal privacy (moderately concerned) versus not being concerned enough to take action (a little concerned) (n=4). Several participants described this difference as the amount of concern, with “moderately concerned” reflecting a higher level of concern (n=13). Some participants described this difference as the amount of time spent thinking about personal privacy, with “moderately concerned” reflecting spending more time

(n=6). Seven participants, five of whom responded in Spanish, did not see a difference between the response options.

In the context of this question, participants did not struggle with the “extremely concerned” response, unlike Q1 and Q5 (discussed previously). However, some participants struggled to choose a response, indicating there may be problems with the scale. One participant said that they wanted a middle response option, without elaborating on why. Another participant at first answered “Not at all concerned” but then changed their answer to “A little concerned” after probing.

One participant commented that a lot of questions had been asking about the government’s access to your data and that they interpreted this question to be about the government.

Recommendations

Overall: Some Issues

As noted during the expert review, context effects seem to have some impact on the way participants answered this question. One participant noted they were specifically thinking about government access to data due to the previous questions. Most participants use the context of the previous questions to inform their understanding of “personal privacy” focused on data/personal information. If this question seeks to measure people’s broad understanding of personal privacy, then the current findings show that the meaning of personal privacy is being interpreted under the context of the survey. This question could be considered for deletion if it was meant to measure people’s broad understanding of personal privacy.

If we keep this question, we should further consider the response options, in conjunction with the findings from other questions using this scale.

Census feedback

The text of Q38 will remain unchanged given that the goal here is to present a general privacy measure, and the Census Bureau expects that context will affect the answers from respondents. See Q05 for discussion of changes implemented to the scale across the instrument, including Q38.

English text

To what extent do you agree or disagree with each of the following statements?

Spanish text

¿Hasta qué punto está usted de acuerdo o en desacuerdo con cada una de las siguientes afirmaciones?

Q39*English text*

People's rights to privacy are well protected.

Spanish text

Los derechos de las personas a la privacidad están bien protegidos.

Table 4-42. Responses to Q39

Response	English n=4	Spanish n=2
Strongly agree Muy de acuerdo	1	0
Somewhat agree Algo de acuerdo	0	2
Neither agree nor disagree Ni de acuerdo ni en desacuerdo	0	0
Somewhat disagree Algo en desacuerdo	2	0
Strongly disagree Muy en desacuerdo	1	0

Q40*English text*

People have lost all control over how personal information about them is used.

Spanish text

Las personas han perdido todo el control sobre cómo se usa su información personal.

Table 4-43. Responses to Q40

Response	English n=4	Spanish n=2
Strongly agree Muy de acuerdo	1	0
Somewhat agree Algo de acuerdo	1	2
Neither agree nor disagree Ni de acuerdo ni en desacuerdo	0	0
Somewhat disagree Algo en desacuerdo	1	0
Strongly disagree Muy en desacuerdo	1	0

Findings (n=6)

Overall, the six participants did not have difficulty understanding or answering either of these questions. In general, participants' answers to these two questions were similar (i.e., agreeing to both or disagreeing to both). However, one participant had opposite reactions to the two questions; they said "Strongly disagree" to Q39 and "Strongly agree" to Q40.

Interestingly, one participant thought that the wording in Q40 ("people have lost all control") was very dramatic and commented, "It's pretty hilarious to phrase it this way after looking at all of these pretty well worded survey questions, then there's this one." She was likely reacting to the strong black and white language used of "all control."

Recommendations

Overall: Few Issues

Given that only six participants reviewed these questions, we have limited data from this testing and recommend no revisions, relying on the Census Bureau's previous testing.

Census feedback

None.

Q41*English text*

The federal government knows more about me than it needs to.

Spanish text

El gobierno federal sabe de mí más de lo que necesita.

Table 4-44. Responses to Q41

Response	English n=4	Spanish n=1
Strongly agree Muy de acuerdo	3	1
Somewhat agree Algo de acuerdo	0	0
Neither agree nor disagree Ni de acuerdo ni en desacuerdo	0	0
Somewhat disagree Algo en desacuerdo	0	0
Strongly disagree Muy en desacuerdo	1	0

Q42*English text*

Private companies have too much information about me.

Spanish text

Las compañías privadas tienen demasiada información sobre mí.

Table 4-45. Responses to Q42

Response	English n=4	Spanish n=1
Strongly agree Muy de acuerdo	2	1
Somewhat agree Algo de acuerdo	1	0
Neither agree nor disagree Ni de acuerdo ni en desacuerdo	0	0
Somewhat disagree Algo en desacuerdo	1	0
Strongly disagree Muy en desacuerdo	0	0

Findings (n=5)

Overall, the five participants who saw and responded to these questions did not have difficulty understanding or answering them.

Recommendations

Overall: Few Issues

Given that only five participants reviewed these questions, we have limited data from this testing and recommend no revisions, relying on the Census Bureau's previous testing.

Census feedback

None.

Q43*English text*

In your opinion, which poses a greater risk to your privacy—private companies or the federal government?

Spanish text

En su opinión, ¿quién representa un riesgo mayor a su privacidad: las compañías privadas o el gobierno federal?

Table 4-46. Responses to Q43

Response	English n=13	Spanish n=14
Private companies Las compañías privadas	8	11
The federal government El gobierno federal	3	1
The risk to my privacy is the same El riesgo a mi privacidad es el mismo	2	1
Unable to answer	0	1

Findings (n=27)

When thinking about risks, participants mainly thought about hacking or data breaches leading to the loss of private information. This interpretation of the question is likely influenced by the context of the previous survey questions. We also found that there were no challenges to the response process identified during testing, but some interesting thematic findings are of note.

Those who selected private companies as a greater risk to their privacy did so because they do not know who is looking at their data, or who it will be sold to (n=5); they think companies have data that has a higher level of privacy, such as financial information, credit cards, and credit reports (n=1); they think companies are less likely to be caught and punished (n=1); companies have had a lot of breaches in the past (n=3); companies have more negative intentions with the data, like being motivated by profits (n=2); companies might disappear in the future, and the federal government is more stable (n=1); and private companies do not always invest in the most stringent cyber security measures (n=1)

Those who selected federal government as a greater risk to their privacy did so because: they think the federal government has more information about them than companies,

representing greater risk if the information is compromised (n=1); they do not have control over what information the federal government has, whereas they do have more control over what companies they interact with (n=1); and because they see the federal government as a single connected entity that can share your information among themselves, while private companies each have to obtain your information individually (n=1).

When reflecting about the federal government posing less risk, participants mentioned that they have a better idea of who is looking at the data (n=1); there are safeguards or laws that offer more protection with the information the federal government has (n=1); and the federal government has less information about them compared to companies because they do not use any federal programs like Medicare/Medicaid or food stamps (n=1).

Those who think the federal government and companies pose the same amount of risk thought that both have had data breaches and both have caused harm (n=2). One participant said that each can be risky and it depends on the people who are behind each one (i.e., the federal government or a private company).

One participant was unable to choose a response and said they wanted to answer that neither posed any risk.

Recommendations

Overall: Few Issues

The changes implemented during the expert review process worked well, including changing “businesses” to “companies” and “government” to “federal government” and the addition of a neutral response option. There are no revisions recommended.

Census feedback

None.

Q44*English text*

Which of the following have you ever done to protect your data or maintain your privacy?

Select all that apply.

Spanish text

¿Cuál de las siguientes medidas ha tomado alguna vez para proteger sus datos o mantener su privacidad?

Seleccione todo lo que corresponda.

Table 4-47. Responses to Q44

English vs. Spanish Responses	English n=7		Spanish n=15	
	Yes	No	Yes	No
English: Signed up for the Do Not Call Registry, which removes your phone number from marketing call lists Spanish: Inscribirse en el Registro No Llame, el cual quita su número de las listas de llamadas para publicidad	14	4	8	6
English: Blocked a smartphone app or stopped an app from accessing other details on your phone, such as your location, contacts, or tracking other activity, to protect your privacy Spanish: Bloquear una aplicación (<i>app</i>) en su teléfono o impedir que una aplicación (<i>app</i>) acceda a otros detalles de su teléfono, como su ubicación, contactos o el seguimiento de otras actividades, para proteger su privacidad	14	4	15	0
English: Changed the settings on your computer or internet browser to increase your privacy Spanish: Cambiar las configuraciones por defecto en su computadora o navegador para aumentar su privacidad	13	5	10	5
English: Avoided or stopped using a social media service to protect privacy Spanish: Evitar o dejar de usar un servicio de redes sociales para proteger la privacidad	11	7	10	4
English: Changed the privacy settings on your social media accounts Spanish: Cambiar las configuraciones de privacidad en sus cuentas de redes sociales	14	4	12	3
English: Refused to answer a survey due to privacy concerns Spanish: Negarse a contestar a una encuesta por motivos de privacidad	6	12	10	5
English: Used more secure methods of communication, such as encrypted emails, to protect your privacy Spanish: Usar métodos de comunicación más seguros, como correos electrónicos encriptados, para proteger su privacidad	8	10	10	5

English vs. Spanish Responses	English n=7		Spanish n=15	
	Yes	No	Yes	No
English: Asked a government department, public service, or private company to delete any information they hold about you Spanish: Solicitar a los departamentos del gobierno, a los servicios públicos o a las compañías privadas que eliminen toda la información que tengan sobre usted	3	15	1	14
English: Froze your credit or requested a notification when a credit check is performed on you Spanish: Congelar su crédito o pedir que le avisen cuando alguien pida su reporte de crédito	2	16	7	8
English: Maintained separate email accounts or alternative phone numbers to protect your privacy Spanish: Mantener cuentas de correo electrónico separadas o diferentes números de teléfono, para proteger su privacidad	5	13	7	8
English: Regularly cleared browser history or deleted cookies Spanish: Borrar regularmente su historial de navegación en el Internet o eliminar las <i>cookies</i>	9	9	14	1
English: Blocked a website from installing cookies Spanish: Bloquear una página de Internet para que no instale <i>cookies</i>	12	6	8	7
English: Asked a government department, public service, or private company what information they hold about you Spanish: Preguntarle a un departamento del gobierno, a un servicio público o a una compañía privada qué tipo de información tiene sobre usted	1	17	5	10

Findings – Original Question Wording (n=25) and New Question Wording (n=15)

Some participants struggled to remember the context provided in the question stem: “protect your data or maintain your privacy.” This finding was clear early on in testing, so “to protect your privacy” was added to several items during testing (as indicated in the question above, highlighted in blue). The item that first clued us into this issue was “Used more secure methods of communications.” Before adding “to protect your privacy,” one participant answered “yes” but indicated that it was for work use. After adding “to protect your privacy,” two participants reflected on the fact that they had used encrypted emails for work but not for personal privacy. They both correctly answered “no.”

One participant, who viewed the new question, was conflicted about how to answer the item “Regularly cleared browser history or deleted cookies.” They noted that they have done this but not to protect their privacy. After rereading the question stem, they correctly answered “no” for this item and reflected that this one did not include “to protect your privacy” as some of the others did. They explained, “You have to keep [privacy] in mind when answering these questions. It's kind of confusing because it's something I've done but not

necessarily to maintain my privacy.” Another participant, who viewed the new question, stated that they would answer “yes” for a few of the items but not for privacy reasons. Further clarification was not gathered.

Overall, most participants felt the items were clear and confidently provided responses. However, participants struggled with a few phrases. First, several participants were unsure what “froze your credit” meant but were all confident they had never done it (n=14). Two participants interpreted this phrase as canceling credit cards, perhaps because they were lost or stolen. One participant was confused about how to answer this question because they had requested a notification for a credit check but had not frozen their credit. They pointed out that this item is double-barreled. They correctly answered “yes” to this item in the end. One participant thought a freeze was when a person calls their bank and asks them to release their information. One participant thought it meant to set an alarm for when there are unrecognized charges so unauthorized people cannot use their credit. Another participant guessed that it might be when someone stops paying bills so that people cannot track their credit.

Another item that some participants struggled with was “Used more secure methods of communications, such as encrypted emails.” Two participants were unclear what “encrypted emails” were; however, both were able to answer “no” without difficulty. One participant was thinking about two-factor authentication instead of encrypted messaging. One participant said they did not understand what was meant by “encriptados” (encrypted) in the context of encrypted emails but that they assumed it was a feature they used from Google. Another Spanish speaker also commented that they did not know that their emails could be encrypted.

Seven participants were not sure about the definition of “cookies.” One of these participants answered “yes” to this item. One participant incorrectly understood cookies as the security filters that websites have. Another guessed that it was an additional charge you could be charged for downloading something from the internet.

One participant chose to leave the item asking about if they “Avoided or stopped using a social media service to protect privacy” blank, commenting that they had not stopped using it but had provided incomplete and fake information to protect their privacy.

In addition to the issues with clarity reported by English speakers, some Spanish speakers commented on not being familiar with some specific terms. Two participants commented that they did not understand what was meant by “configuraciones por defecto” (default settings). Another participant also asked about the term but did understand it as intended when asked to elaborate on their understanding. Six Spanish-speaking participants had never heard of “El Registro No Llame” (The Do Not Call Registry). Two Spanish-speaking participants also commented on the two items that reference asking “a government department, public service, or private company” to either share what information they have

about you or delete your information. They said that they would have no idea how to ask the government to do these things if they wanted to.

A few participants faced some challenges with the item “Blocked a smartphone app or stopped an app from accessing other details on your phone, such as your location, contacts, or tracking other activity.” One participant, who saw the original question, answered “yes” but revealed during probing that she stopped an app from accessing other details on her phone because she was concerned about battery life, not privacy. One participant initially thought about deleting apps, then during probing thought about changing app settings. Another participant who saw the original question changed their answer from “no” to “yes” during probing, but it was unclear why. One Spanish-speaking participant commented that they imagined it was like when you block someone on Facebook. Another Spanish-speaking participant was thinking about how they often block the phone numbers from which they get text message ads on their phone, rather than blocking apps from accessing information from their phone.

One participant brought up the word “regularly” when responding to the item “Regularly cleared browser history or deleted cookies.” This participant reflected that they did not regularly clear browser history or delete cookies, saying “no, not regularly” as they selected the response “no.” This indicates that “regularly” may be influencing responses for some people.

Most participants thought the list was exhaustive, but a few mentioned additional measures they have taken to protect their privacy: using two-factor identification or VPN (n=1); blocking phone calls; choosing iPhone over Android due to additional privacy measures (n=1); not providing personal information over the phone or asking questions to confirm legitimacy when receiving calls about personal information (n=2); and deleting one’s credit card information from websites (n=1).

Recommendations

Overall: Some Issues

Evidence from testing indicates that including “to protect your privacy” is necessary in the items to cement the context for participants, contradictory to recommendations from the expert report. This idea was illustrated clearly with the addition of this phrase to the item about encrypted emails.

The many items in the table and the fact that the question stem did not stay on screen likely contributed to the improved performance of items with the phrase “to protect your privacy.” In addition to the changes already implemented during testing, it would also be useful to program the question stem to stay on screen while participants evaluate all items in the grid.

Keeping the question stem on screen should help keep the privacy context in mind for participants, but all items should be examined with the key findings in mind as we consider whether to add “to protect your privacy” to additional items, such as “cleared browser history.”

Due to the issues some participants had around understanding and responding to the item about blocking or stopping an app on their smartphone, we recommend shortening the text to reduce cognitive burden. The suggested change is as follows: “Stopped a smartphone app from tracking your location, contacts, or other activity to protect your privacy.”

Although participants struggled with “froze your credit,” it does not impact the response process because it is clear to them whether they have taken this action or not.

We also have less concern about participants who are unable to verbalize the definition of “cookies.” Given the regular interactions people have with accepting cookies on websites, they should be able to answer accurately even with misunderstandings of the term “cookies.”

We may want to consider the analytic goals of the item “regularly cleared browser history or deleted cookies” and whether it is important to measure frequency of this privacy behavior. “Regularly” may lead to a varied interpretation, and we may consider something more concrete such as “weekly” or “monthly.” Alternatively, if the analytic goal is focused on ever performing this behavior, then “regularly” could be dropped from the statement.

Although a few participants mentioned other measures they have taken to protect their privacy, the most common measures seem well-represented. We do not recommend adding additional items.

Though there were some comprehension issues that appear to have been worse among Spanish speakers than English speakers, specifically related to freezing credit, encrypted emails, default settings, and the Do-Not-Call registry, we do not believe these are translation related, but rather stem from a generally lower level of familiarity with the concepts and technologies among the Spanish-speaking participants. For this reason, we do not recommend any changes to the translations.

Census feedback

For the web instrument for the national data collection, the question stem of Q44 will be programmed to stay on screen while respondents evaluate all items in the grid. We agree to include the clause “to protect your privacy” for the corresponding items as recommended and revise the second item’s wording to “Blocked a smartphone app from tracking your location, contacts, or accessing other details to protect your privacy.”

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Appendix A. Original Survey Questions

The questions in this survey ask about your opinions on data collection and privacy. Thank you for agreeing to participate.

1. How concerned are you, if at all, about how companies are using the data they collect about you?
 - ☐ Extremely concerned
 - ☐ Very concerned
 - ☐ Somewhat concerned
 - ☐ A little concerned
 - ☐ Not at all concerned
2. How much do you feel you personally benefit from the data that companies collect about you?
 - ☐ A great deal
 - ☐ Some
 - ☐ Very little
 - ☐ None
3. How much control do you think you have over the data that companies collect about you?
 - ☐ A great deal of control
 - ☐ Some control
 - ☐ Very little control
 - ☐ No control
4. How concerned are you, if at all, about how the government is using the data it collects about you?
 - ☐ Extremely concerned
 - ☐ Very concerned
 - ☐ Somewhat concerned
 - ☐ A little concerned
 - ☐ Not at all concerned

5. How much do you feel you personally benefit from the data the government collects about you?
 - A great deal
 - Some
 - Very little
 - None
6. How much do you feel your community benefits from the data the government collects about you?
 - A great deal
 - Some
 - Very little
 - None
7. How much do you feel you understand what the government is doing with the data it collects about you?
 - A great deal
 - Some
 - Very little
 - Nothing
8. Which of the following statements comes closest to your opinion?
 - The benefits I get from companies collecting data about me outweigh the potential risks
 - The potential risks of companies collecting data about me outweigh the benefits I get
9. Which of the following statements comes closest to your opinion?
 - The benefits the government can provide by collecting data about me outweigh the potential risks
 - The potential risks of the government collecting data about me outweigh the benefits it can provide
10. Which of the following statements comes closest to your opinion?
 - The benefits the government can provide by collecting data about my community outweigh the potential risks
 - The potential risks of the government collecting data about my community outweigh the benefits it can provide

11. Do you believe government data collection can harm your community?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

12. How willing are you to share your data with the **Federal** government?

- ☐ Very willing
- ☐ Moderately willing
- ☐ Somewhat willing
- ☐ Slightly willing
- ☐ Not at all willing

13. What about your STATE government? How willing are you to share your data with your STATE government?

- ☐ Very willing
- ☐ Moderately willing
- ☐ Somewhat willing
- ☐ Slightly willing
- ☐ Not at all willing

14. What about your LOCAL government? How willing are you to share your data with your LOCAL government?

- ☐ Very willing
- ☐ Moderately willing
- ☐ Somewhat willing
- ☐ Slightly willing
- ☐ Not at all willing

15. Do you think federal government agencies share a single central database of the name, address, and date of birth of U.S. residents?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

16. Do you think that federal government agencies SHOULD share a single central database of the name, address, and date of birth of U.S. residents?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

- 17.** Government agencies already collect data about people's jobs, earnings, and participation in government programs but do not always share the data between agencies. If these separate data sources could be combined while keeping them strictly confidential, would you be in favor of or against combining these data sources?
- ☐ Strongly in favor of it
 - ☐ Somewhat in favor of it
 - ☐ Neither in favor nor against it
 - ☐ Somewhat against it
 - ☐ Strongly against it
- 18.** The Census Bureau is considering linking together the information that individuals have given to federal, state, and local agencies when applying for benefits and services, when filing your taxes, or filling out surveys like your census form. This information would only be used to produce statistics. Would you be in favor or against linking information about individuals?
- ☐ Strongly in favor of it
 - ☐ Somewhat in favor of it
 - ☐ Neither in favor nor against it
 - ☐ Somewhat against it
 - ☐ Strongly against it
- 19.** The Census Bureau is also considering using information about individuals available from commercial sources. For example, your contact information from private companies. Would you be in favor or against the Census Bureau obtaining your information from commercial sources?
- ☐ Strongly in favor of it
 - ☐ Somewhat in favor of it
 - ☐ Neither in favor nor against it
 - ☐ Somewhat against it
 - ☐ Strongly against it
- 20.** Access to Social Security numbers makes it easier to combine information from different agencies and to link individuals to their information. If the Census Bureau asked for your Social Security number, would you be willing to provide it?
- ☐ Yes
 - ☐ No

- 21.** The Census Bureau plans to build a new database that brings together information from other government agencies, government surveys you may have answered in the past, and commercial sources. This database will [FRAME]. The database would only be used to produce statistics. Would you be in favor of this database or against this database?

FRAME 1: mean that you are asked you to fill out surveys less often because your information is already available.

FRAME 2: help government agencies save taxpayer money by becoming more efficient.

FRAME 3: help your local government deliver services and benefits more efficiently.

FRAME 4: mean that data and statistics are more accurate.

FRAME 5: help fill in responses when information is missing.

- Strongly in favor of it
- Somewhat in favor of it
- Neither in favor nor against it
- Somewhat against it
- Strongly against it

- 22.** Below is a list of reasons why someone might support a Census Bureau database that brings together information from various sources for producing statistics. Please answer whether each reason would make you in favor of or against this database.

Strongly in favor Somewhat in favor Neither Somewhat against Strongly against

FRAME 1

FRAME 2

FRAME 3

FRAME 4

FRAME 5

23. Different government departments and services collect data about individuals for specific purposes. For example, the IRS collects your income and other information for tax purposes. People have different views about whether this data should be used for new purposes after it has been collected. Reusing data for new purposes can bring benefits such as planning roads and schools for local communities, saving taxpayer money by collecting less data, and making benefits and services more efficient. How comfortable are you with your data being used for new purposes after it has been collected?

- Absolutely comfortable
- Very comfortable
- Somewhat comfortable
- A little comfortable
- Not at all comfortable

Ask Q22 if Q21 does not equal Absolutely comfortable or very comfortable

24. You said you were [only somewhat comfortable/ only a little comfortable/ not at all comfortable] with your data being used for new purposes after it has been collected. Please explain why you answered the way you did. [Open-ended]

Would you be in favor of or against the Census Bureau getting the following types of information from other government agencies?

25. Your contact information, like phone numbers and email addresses

- Strongly in favor of it
- Somewhat in favor of it
- Neither in favor nor against it
- Somewhat against it
- Strongly against it

26. Whether your address was occupied or vacant on a particular date

- Strongly in favor of it
- Somewhat in favor of it
- Neither in favor nor against it
- Somewhat against it
- Strongly against it

27. Your demographic information, like age and marital status

- Strongly in favor of it
- Somewhat in favor of it
- Neither in favor nor against it
- Somewhat against it
- Strongly against it

28. Whether your home is owned or rented

- Strongly in favor of it
- Somewhat in favor of it
- Neither in favor nor against it
- Somewhat against it
- Strongly against it

29. Your income in the last year

- Strongly in favor of it
- Somewhat in favor of it
- Neither in favor nor against it
- Somewhat against it
- Strongly against it

30. The number of people in your household

- Strongly in favor of it
- Somewhat in favor of it
- Neither in favor nor against it
- Somewhat against it
- Strongly against it

Would you be in favor of or against the Census Bureau getting your information from the following sources?

31. The Social Security Administration (SSA)

- Strongly in favor of it
- Somewhat in favor of it
- Neither in favor nor against it
- Somewhat against it
- Strongly against it

32. The Internal Revenue Service (IRS)

- Strongly in favor of it
- Somewhat in favor of it
- Neither in favor nor against it
- Somewhat against it
- Strongly against it

33. Your state department of motor vehicles

- Strongly in favor of it
- Somewhat in favor of it
- Neither in favor nor against it
- Somewhat against it
- Strongly against it

34. A credit reporting company, like Experian or Equifax

- Strongly in favor of it
- Somewhat in favor of it
- Neither in favor nor against it
- Somewhat against it
- Strongly against it

35. Your county tax assessor or collector

- Strongly in favor of it
- Somewhat in favor of it
- Neither in favor nor against it
- Somewhat against it
- Strongly against it

36. The population count, the crime rate, and the unemployment rate are examples of statistics produced by the federal government. Have you ever used federal statistics for study or work?

- ☐ Yes, I have used federal statistics for study or work
- ☐ No, I have not used federal statistics for study or work

37. Personally, how much trust do you have in federal statistics in the United States? Would you say that you tend to trust federal statistics or you tend not to trust them?

- ☐ Tend to trust federal statistics
- ☐ Tend not to trust federal statistics

Do you agree or disagree with the following statement?

38. Policy makers need federal statistics to make good decisions about things like federal funding.

- ☐ Strongly agree
- ☐ Somewhat agree
- ☐ Neither agree nor disagree
- ☐ Somewhat disagree
- ☐ Strongly disagree

39. Have you ever heard of information being stolen through hacking or a data breach?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

40. How concerned are you about information you give to the Census Bureau being stolen through hacking or a data breach?

- ☐ Not at all concerned
- ☐ Slightly concerned
- ☐ Somewhat concerned
- ☐ Moderately concerned
- ☐ Very concerned

41. How likely do you think it is that information you give the Census Bureau will be stolen through hacking or a data breach?

- ☐ Not at all likely
- ☐ A little bit likely
- ☐ Moderately likely
- ☐ Very likely

The following questions are about your opinions on privacy.

42. In general, how concerned would you say you are about your personal privacy?

- ☐ Extremely concerned
- ☐ Very concerned
- ☐ Somewhat concerned
- ☐ A little concerned
- ☐ Not at all concerned

Do you agree or disagree with each of the following statements?

43. People's rights to privacy are well protected.

- ☐ Strongly agree
- ☐ Somewhat agree
- ☐ Neither agree nor disagree
- ☐ Somewhat disagree
- ☐ Strongly disagree

44. People have lost all control over how personal information about them is used.

- ☐ Strongly agree
- ☐ Somewhat agree
- ☐ Neither agree nor disagree
- ☐ Somewhat disagree
- ☐ Strongly disagree

45. The government knows more about me than it needs to.

- ☐ Strongly agree
- ☐ Somewhat agree
- ☐ Neither agree nor disagree
- ☐ Somewhat disagree
- ☐ Strongly disagree

46. Businesses and private industry have too much information about me.

- ☐ Strongly agree
- ☐ Somewhat agree
- ☐ Neither agree nor disagree
- ☐ Somewhat disagree
- ☐ Strongly disagree

47. Which poses a greater risk to your privacy—businesses and private industry, or the government?

- ☐ Businesses and private industry
- ☐ The government

48. Have you done any of these things to protect your data or avoid intrusion into your privacy?

Select all that apply.

- ☐ Signed up for the Do Not Call Registry, which removes your number from marketing call lists
- ☐ Blocked a smartphone app or stopped an app from accessing other details on your phone, such as GPS location or your contacts
- ☐ Changed the default settings on your computer or browser to increase your privacy
- ☐ Stopped or avoided using a social media service so that you can protect your privacy
- ☐ Changed the privacy settings on your social media accounts
- ☐ Refused to answer a survey due to privacy concerns
- ☐ Started using more secure methods of communication, such as encrypted emails
- ☐ Asked a government department, public service, or private company to delete any information they hold about you
- ☐ Stopped using store loyalty cards so that you can protect your privacy
- ☐ Asked a government department, public service or private company what information they hold about you
- ☐ None of these

49. What sex were you assigned at birth, on your original birth certificate?

- ☐ Male
- ☐ Female

50. Do you currently describe yourself as male, female or transgender?

- ☐ Male
- ☐ Female
- ☐ Transgender
- ☐ None of these

51. Just to confirm, you were assigned [FILL-Q49 response] at birth and now you describe yourself as [FILL-Q50 response]. Is that correct?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

52. Which of the following best represents how you think of yourself?

- ☐ Lesbian or gay
- ☐ Straight, that is not lesbian or gay
- ☐ Bisexual
- ☐ Something else (please specify: _____)
- ☐ I don't know

53. What is your age?

54. Are you of Hispanic, Latino, or Spanish origin?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

55. What is your race? (*mark all that apply*)

- ☐ White
- ☐ Black or African American
- ☐ American Indian or Alaska Native
- ☐ Asian
- ☐ Native Hawaiian or Other Pacific Islander
- ☐ Some other race

56. What is the highest level of school you have completed or the highest degree you have received?

- ☐ Less than high school
- ☐ Completed high school
- ☐ Some college, no degree
- ☐ Associate's degree (AA/AS)
- ☐ Bachelor's degree (BA/BS)
- ☐ Post-Bachelor's Degree

57. Were you born in the United States?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

58. What is your marital status?

- ☐ Single
- ☐ Married
- ☐ Widowed
- ☐ Divorced
- ☐ Separated

59. The next question asks about your income. We use this information only to produce statistics. The Census Bureau is required by law to keep your information confidential. What is your total ANNUAL household income, before taxes? *Please include income from wages and salaries, self-employment, retirement income, interest and dividends, unemployment benefits, and any other sources of income received regularly.*

- ☐ \$ Under \$23,999
- ☐ \$24,000 to \$35,999
- ☐ \$36,000 to \$47,999
- ☐ \$48,000 to \$59,999
- ☐ \$60,000 to \$89,999
- ☐ \$90,000 to \$119,999
- ☐ \$120,000 to \$179,999
- ☐ \$180,000 to \$239,999
- ☐ \$240,000 and over
- ☐ Don't know
- ☐ Prefer not to answer

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